

Raising Believers

*Christian Parenting and the Costly Work of Forming Faith
in a Post-Christian World*

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Raising Believers

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Contents

Introduction. The Faith You Cannot Transmit
Chapter 1. What We Mean When We Say Formation
Chapter 2. The Home Is the Primary Catechism
Chapter 3. When the Church Replaces the Parent
Chapter 4. The Questions Children Actually Ask
Chapter 5. Obedience Without Gospel
Chapter 6. Discipline, Correction, and the Shape of Grace
Chapter 7. Screens, Algorithms, and the Catechesis of Attention
Chapter 8. Marriage as the First Classroom
Chapter 9. The Teenage Years, When Formation Goes Underground
Chapter 10. Fathers, Presence, and the Weight of Blessing
Chapter 11. Single Parents, Blended Families, and the God Who Holds
Chapter 12. Grandparents and the Long Memory of Faith
Chapter 13. When They Walk Away
Conclusion. The Long Obedience of Raising Believers

INTRODUCTION

The Faith You Cannot Transmit

*Why so many children raised in Christian homes
leave the faith — and what bedtime devotions,
Sunday school, and youth group were never built
to do.*

I have five sons, and I have been a pastor long enough to have baptized children I once held as infants, which means I have sat, over the years, in two kinds of living rooms that have never stopped haunting me. In the first sit parents in their sixties whose grown children no longer claim the faith; in the second, parents in their thirties, watching their own toddlers and terrified of ending up in the first room. Something has broken in the way Christian households form children — and no curriculum, however good, is going to fix it.

This is a book for the parents who already sense that, who have done the bedtime devotionals and the Sunday school drop-offs and the years of youth group volunteering and still carry a quiet suspicion that something is not

Let me be plain about what this book is not. It is not a program, and it is not thirteen steps to raise godly children — the shelf is already crowded with those, and most of them sell the same quiet lie: that if you run the right process on your child, you will get the right output. You will not, because children are not processes and faith is not an output, and the parent who believes otherwise will be devastated either by a child who performs compliance without conviction or by a child who, sooner or later, stops performing at all.

What this book argues is slower and far more uncomfortable, because faith forms in children the way it forms in anyone — through the weight of a life lived near other lives that actually believe, through the presence of adults who are not pretending, through questions answered rather than deflected, and through a household whose ordinary rhythms say, over years and without announcing it, that God is real and that following Him is the most serious thing we do.

That kind of formation cannot be outsourced; it cannot be scheduled into thirty-minute devotions everyone dreads, it cannot be purchased in a curriculum, and it cannot be handed off to the youth pastor, God bless the youth pastor. Faith forms in the soil of a home, and where the soil is thin, nothing grows — no matter how good the seeds are.

THE KITCHEN WHERE THIS BEGAN

This book did not start in a study. It started in my kitchen, about six years ago, when one of my older boys looked at me in the middle of a family devotional and asked, Dad, do you actually want to be doing this right now. He was not being disrespectful; he was being observant. He had watched me check my phone twice during the reading, watched my eyes glaze over my own questions, watched me rush the prayer because I still had emails waiting — and so he was not questioning the faith at all. He was questioning me, asking whether the thing we were doing mattered to the person who kept insisting it mattered.

I wish I could tell you I handled it well. I gave a defensive little speech about the importance of family devotions, and he did not respond, because he did not need to; his point settled into me over the following weeks like a stone dropping slowly through water. He was right. The devotional had become a performance — I was checking a box, my sons could see it, and they were

So I want to be careful about the diagnosis, because it is not that Christian parents are failing their children. It is that Christian parents were sold a model of formation that was never going to work, and many of them have run that model with great faithfulness and are now grieving the results. If that is you, I am not here to add guilt; I am here to name what was wrong, and to point toward something older and slower and harder and, I believe, more honest.

THE PASTOR'S CHAIR: WHY CHRISTIAN KIDS LEAVE THE CHURCH

The view from this chair is different from the view from the pew. I watch families doing everything right by every metric the evangelical world has handed them — regular attendance, small group, missions giving, Bible memory — and I watch their children leave, not at the margins but at the center. The most committed families in my church are sometimes the ones whose children walk away with the most resolve, because those children got the full version of the model and found it wanting.

I also watch families nobody would ever put on a poster — families that are messy, that miss Sundays, that have never finished a single study — and their kids are walking with Jesus in their twenties and thirties. When you ask those kids why, they tell you the same thing, almost word for word: my parents were real. They were not impressive;

That observation, repeated across twenty years of ministry, is where this book comes from — not a theory but a pattern, consistent enough that I am now willing to call it a principle: faith forms in proximity to a real life, not in exposure to a right program. And the implications are uncomfortable for a generation of parents who invested heavily in programs and lightly in their own interior lives.

Some of you came to this book because of the statistics. The numbers shift depending on who counts and how they define their terms, but the picture is clear enough: somewhere between forty and sixty percent of young adults raised in evangelical homes are walking away from the church by their mid-twenties. Not all of them abandon faith entirely — some move to other traditions, some to a private spirituality with no community, some to nothing at all — but the exodus is real, it is large, and it has been growing for three decades.

The common evangelical response has been to build better programs — better youth ministries, better apologetics, better college transition strategies, better worship engineered to keep young people engaged — and none of these is wrong in itself, yet all of them miss the point. The programs were not bad; the programs were simply being asked to do what only a household can do, while the households behind all that program attendance were teaching a different catechism than the one the programs taught.

This is not a comfortable diagnosis, but it is the one I believe is true, and I have staked the book on it: if I am

THE FORTRESS AND THE PRESENCE

The old model runs roughly like this. Christian formation is primarily cognitive, so the task is to get the child to believe the right things by stacking the content — Sunday school, Awana, VBS, youth group, Christian school if you can manage it — and then to build the behavioral guardrails around it: no this, no that, yes to this, layered in with the right music, the right friends, the right media. You hold the line until eighteen, then release the child into the world and hope.

I call this the fortress model. You build the walls and fill the interior with the right content, you patrol the perimeter to keep the bad out and the good in, and when you finally release the child you hope the fortress held long enough that they will carry the architecture out on their own. The problem is threefold.

First, the fortress is permeable, and it always was. In 1985 the fortress had cracks; in 2026 it has a smartphone-sized hole in the wall that connects to every idea, image, and ideology our species has ever produced. The wall cannot hold. It was only ever built to hold until the next Sunday, and even that is optimistic now.

Second, the fortress produces a child who knows what is inside the walls and what is outside them but who has never actually been taught to think. The right answers

Third, and worst, the fortress treats the child as a container to be filled rather than a person to be formed: good content in, bad content out, while the child's own curiosity, doubt, desire, and interior life are not part of the equation at all. They are not trusted; they are managed. And a child whose interior life has been managed rather than formed will, at the first opportunity, seize the interior life that was never given to him. From the parent's chair that seizure usually looks like rebellion. It is not rebellion. It is a person becoming a person — and the tragedy is only that it happens outside the faith, because it was never permitted to happen inside it.

I have a different model to offer, and it is not new; it is very old. It is the way faith was actually passed down for most of Christian history — before the programmatic era, before age-graded infrastructure, before we assumed formation was something you do to a child rather than something that happens near one. The model is presence: formed presence, over time, in ordinary rooms.

It works like this. A parent who is being formed by Christ, who is honest about that, who has a real interior life with God and lets that life show in ordinary moments, who answers hard questions instead of deflecting them, who

This does not mean the parent must be impressive; it means the parent must be real, because a parent whose faith is small but honest does more for formation than a parent whose faith is large but performed. Children do not need a parent who has all the answers. They need a parent whose life makes the questions worth asking.

The old model has many problems, and the chapters ahead work through them in order: it treats faith as a transferable body of information rather than a formed way of being; it casts the parent as a manager of inputs rather than the primary curriculum; it outsources the part of formation that cannot be outsourced; it meets a child's real questions with a performance of certainty the child can usually see through by middle school; it mistakes compliance for conviction, and never reckons with how discipline either forms or deforms a child's image of God. It ignores what screens are doing to the attention of anyone under eighteen, forgets that a child's first formation environment is the marriage and not the family devotional, and has no theology for the teenage years, when formation goes underground and the parent must learn an entirely different posture. It has let fathers become ornamental, has no word for the single parent or the blended family or the grandparent raising grandchildren, no place for the role grandparents play in intergenerational faith — and no theology at all for what you do when a child walks away.

*You cannot give your children a faith
you do not have.*

If your own faith is thin, if it runs on performance, if it has shrunk to attendance and correct opinions, if you have not wrestled with God in a long time and have quietly stopped being hungry for His presence, then what you pass on will be thin too — not because your children are rejecting anything, but because there is nothing substantial there for them to reject.

I learned this the hard way, not from a book but from watching my own children absorb not what I said but what I was. They did not absorb my sermons; they absorbed my Monday mornings. They did not absorb my theology of prayer; they absorbed whether I actually prayed when no one was performing. They did not absorb my lectures about Scripture; they absorbed whether the Bible on my nightstand had been opened that week or whether it was simply furniture.

Children are the most honest theologians in the house. They evaluate the adults every day, and they are not evaluating what the adults say — they are evaluating the gap between what the adults say and what the adults are. When the gap is small, faith forms; when the gap is wide, something else forms, something that looks like faith on

This is the hope, and it is also the cost. The hope is that the most important thing you can do for your children's faith is to attend to your own — you do not need a better curriculum, you need a deeper life. The cost is that there is no shortcut: you cannot outsource this, and you cannot catch up at fourteen after twelve years of practical absence. The work begins in the parent's interior life, works outward through the texture of a home, and compounds quietly over years.

FOR THE CHRISTIAN PARENT WHO FEELS DISQUALIFIED

I want to say a word to the parents who need this book most, because they are the ones most likely to feel disqualified by it. You have already failed — and I do not mean that as a judgment, I mean it as a fact. You have already said the wrong thing at the wrong moment, already lost your temper when your child needed your steadiness, already chosen the screen over the conversation, the schedule over the person, the shortcut over the investment. You have failed. So have I. The question is not whether you have failed; the question is whether the failure is the last word.

It is not — and the reason has nothing to do with your competence. It has to do with the grace of a God who has been forming people through imperfect parents since the garden. Abraham lied, Isaac played favorites, Jacob manipulated, Moses lost his temper, David was absent from his sons in the years that mattered most — and God

I once counseled a father in his late fifties who had spent his career building a business and his evenings in front of the television. His children were raised in church but had never seen their father pray outside a meal, never heard him say what God meant to him, never watched him open a Bible that was not in a pew rack; his faith was real but invisible, and his children, now in their thirties, had concluded it was a social convention rather than a living reality. He came to me because his youngest daughter had told him, in a conversation that shook him, that she had stopped believing in God — not because of any argument, but because she had never seen any evidence that her father actually believed.

He asked me what he could do, and I told him three things: become the man you wish you had been, not as a strategy to win her back but as obedience to the God who is still forming you; tell her the truth, that your faith was real but you hid it, and that hiding it was wrong; and pray for her every single day, by name, and do not stop. He did all three. His daughter has not returned to the faith as I write this, but the father is a different man, and the door has been open now for three years, and the daughter knows it is open — because the father has become the kind of man who keeps it open.

This book is for that father as much as for the mother of

One last thing I have to be honest about: this book is not a guarantee. I cannot promise that if you follow every principle in these pages your children will walk with Jesus into adulthood, because I know families who did everything right, or close to it, and watched their children walk away, and I know families who did almost nothing deliberate and whose children are among the most faithful believers I have ever met. The sovereignty of God is real, and it means the outcome is not entirely in your hands. What is in your hands is the soil.

You can tend the soil, you can pull the weeds, you can water the ground — but whether the seed sprouts and grows to its full height is between the seed and the God

So turn the page, if you would rather have the truth than the comfortable lie that you can give your children what you have not yet let God give you. This book does not end in a neat resolution, and it cannot, because the work of raising believing children does not resolve; it continues past their childhood, past their leaving home, past your ability to control any outcome, into the years when your only tools are prayer and presence and the open door. I will prepare you for as much of that road as I can see from where I stand. The rest belongs to God, and His vision is longer than mine. We have rooms to walk through.

CHAPTER ONE

What We Mean When We Say Formation

What spiritual formation actually is — how a child's faith is shaped by years lived near believing adults, not by curriculum or quizzes.

There is a word we throw around in Christian parenting circles, and most of the time we are using it to mean something it does not mean: formation. We have made it a dressed-up synonym for teaching, or for discipline, or for the whole package of Sunday school and family devotions and good habits — when formation is in fact older and stranger than any of that. If we are going to raise children in the faith, we have to recover what it actually is.

Formation is what happens to a human being who spends years near a particular kind of presence; it is slower than teaching and deeper than behavior, and it does not produce outputs on a predictable timeline. You cannot measure it in a catechism quiz. You recognize it later, when you notice that a person thinks a certain way, responds a certain way, carries a certain weight — and you

Most Christian parents are running an education strategy and calling it formation, and the strategy goes like this: get the right content into the child, protect the child from the wrong content, structure enough repetition to make the content stick, and hope the content becomes conviction. That is education. It is not formation. It can be part of formation, but it is never the whole of it, and when it is treated as the whole, it produces children who know the right answers and have no interior connection to the God those answers describe.

Somewhere in the second half of the twentieth century, American evangelicalism made a decisive turn toward information as the primary vehicle of spiritual growth — and there were reasons. The fundamentalist-modernist controversy of the early 1900s had produced a Christianity suspicious of experience, suspicious of mystery, suspicious of anything that could not be printed on a doctrinal statement; the way you knew someone was Christian was that they believed the right propositions, and the way you formed a Christian child was that you got the right propositions into them early enough and often enough that they stuck.

This was not entirely wrong. Doctrine matters, content matters, and a child who grows up with no biblical knowledge is not formed in the faith. But the emphasis on information did something its advocates did not intend: it reduced the Christian life to a set of ideas to be believed rather than a way of being to be inhabited. And once the Christian life is a set of ideas, you can deliver it through

Formation did not follow. Not because the information was wrong. Because information is not formation.

I grew up without a father, and I did not grow up Christian; I came to faith in college, through a roommate who did not lecture me and a visitor to our apartment who answered my actual questions rather than the questions he wished I were asking. What shaped my early faith was not a curriculum but being near people who were believing in a way I had not encountered before — I watched how they handled disappointment, how they treated women, how they talked about money, how they prayed when they thought I was not listening. That was formation. The content came later. The formation came first.

THE CATECHUMENATE: HOW THE EARLY CHURCH FORMED FAITH

The early church understood this. Before there were catechism books, before there were Sunday school curricula, before there were children's Bibles with cartoon illustrations, there was the catechumenate — the process by which a person was formed into the faith over one to three years. It included instruction, but the instruction was embedded in a life: the catechumen lived among believers, watched them pray, watched them fast, watched them serve the poor, watched them suffer, watched them

When Paul wrote to Timothy, he did not say, I taught you the right content and therefore you are formed. He wrote something else:

You have followed my teaching, my conduct, my aim in life, my faith, my patience, my love, my steadfastness, my persecutions and sufferings.

– 2 TIMOTHY 3:10-11

That is a formation inventory. Teaching is first on the list, but the list does not stop there — it includes conduct, aim, faith, patience, love, steadfastness, and it includes suffering. Timothy was formed by proximity to a life; the teaching was part of the formation, not the formation itself.

Now consider how most Christian households operate. The parents have the content — the Bibles, the podcasts, the sermons, the small group material — and the children are exposed to it, but the children are not forming near believing parents so much as near parents who attend Christian events, and there is a difference. A parent can be in Christian spaces every week and have no formed interior life, and a child raised near that parent receives the externals without the center — which is precisely the recipe for what we used to call pharisaism and now call church culture.

I have watched this play out for twenty years in pastoral ministry, and the families where the children's faith has gone the distance are not the families that attended the most programs; they are the families where the parents had an actual life with God that was visible in ordinary

PROXIMITY TO A LIFE: HOW CHILDREN CATCH FAITH

Formation is not something you do to a child; it is something that happens in proximity — and proximity to what? Proximity to a life that is actually being lived under the lordship of Christ. Your kitchen is a formation space, and so is your car on the way to school, and so is the way you treat your spouse at seven fifteen in the morning, and so is the way you respond to the email from your boss that you did not want to receive. Your child is reading all of it. The child reads what you actually are, not what you say you are, because the child has been watching you long enough to know the difference.

That is why formation is terrifying: you cannot fake it over the timeline a child has with you. You can fake it on Sunday morning in front of people who see you two hours a week, but you cannot fake it in front of a seven-year-old who has watched you for two thousand five hundred days. The child knows. The child knows whether prayer in your home is a ritual that adults perform for the child's benefit or whether the adults in this house actually pray; whether the Bible is a reference book that gets pulled out for

*A parent whose faith is small but
honest does more for formation than a
parent whose faith is extensive but
performative.*

This does not mean your interior life has to be impressive; it means it has to be real. The child is not impressed by theological vocabulary — the child is watching for alignment. When the words the parent says about God line up with the way the parent is actually living, something forms; when they do not line up, something also forms, and it is the thing we are all grieving in the generation leaving the church right now. They did not leave because the teaching was too demanding. They left because the teaching and the life did not match, and they noticed.

Formation is happening at all times, in all directions; you are not choosing whether to form your children, you are choosing in which direction. A home that runs on anxiety is forming anxious children, a home that runs on performance is forming performers, a home that runs on conflict avoidance is forming people who will not name truth when it costs them, and a home that runs on consumption is forming consumers — and none of those

THE FORMATION OF THE PARENT COMES FIRST

This is why the formation of a child begins with the formation of the parent — and I will say it a dozen times in this book because it cannot be said too often. The parent's own walk with Christ is not a private devotional matter; it is the soil in which the child's faith will grow or will not. A parent being sanctified, slowly and honestly and visibly, creates a different household than a parent performing sanctification, and the child does not know the word sanctification — the child only knows whether the parent is changing.

Here is the part I have to say because I need to hear it myself: you cannot curriculum your way out of your own lack of life with God. You can buy better books, enroll in better schools, join better churches, and none of it touches the problem if the problem is that your own walk with Jesus has flattened out. Children form around the center of a parent's actual life — if the center is work, they will form around work; if the center is appearance, they will form around appearance; if the center is Christ, they will form around Christ. The center is not what you say it is. It is what your week actually shows.

I have to name a particular failure I have seen in pastors' homes, including my own. Pastors are professionally Christian — their work is Christ, their

The hope in this chapter is small and heavy: it is that formation in your children is doable — not easy, not quick, not guaranteed, but doable, because the lever is not external to you. It is the thing you already have direct access to, which is your own life before God. You cannot control what your children will choose when they are grown; you can only be the kind of person near whom formation in a Christlike direction is more likely than not — honest instead of performative, hungry instead of settled, present instead of distracted, slow to anger when the children press on the places your flesh wants to hide. That is what formation is. Proximity to a formed life. Over years. In ordinary rooms. With a thousand small honesties along the way.

WHAT A THOUSAND ORDINARY MORNINGS DO

Because the concept can feel abstract, let me describe

In the first home, the alarm goes off and the household immediately enters management mode: the parent is on the phone before their feet touch the floor, breakfast is functional, and the conversation, such as it is, is about logistics — who needs to be where, what needs to be signed. The parent is tense because they are late, and the children absorb the tension; nobody prays, nobody mentions God, and the Bible on the counter is under a stack of mail. The parent drops the children at school with a hurried goodbye and drives to work listening to a podcast about productivity. The morning has catechized the children in a theology of urgency — the world is demanding, there is not enough time, the most important thing is efficiency, and God is not in the morning but somewhere else, for later.

In the second home, the household wakes up at roughly the same speed. The parent is tired, the morning is not serene, and there is still cereal to pour and permission slips to find — but somewhere in the first fifteen minutes the parent pauses, not for long, for ninety seconds, and says, out loud, at the table: Lord, thank you for this day. Be with these boys today. Help me be patient. The children hear it. They do not respond, because they are eating cereal, but they hear it. The parent is not performing a devotional; the parent is doing what the parent does every morning, taking thirty seconds to orient the household toward God before the logistics take over. On the drive to school, the parent asks the child about something the child mentioned the night before — not school, something personal — and the child, surprised at being remembered,

Neither morning is dramatic, and neither will be remembered by the child as a specific event — but multiply each one by a thousand, and you have two entirely different formation environments. The first produces a child who sees God as an addition to an already full life; the second produces a child who sees God as the orienting reality of the household. Formation is what a thousand mornings do. It is not what one sermon says. It is the accumulated weight of a life lived in a particular direction, and the child, who is in the room for all of it, absorbs the direction even when they are not paying attention.

Parents tell me they do not have time for formation, that life is too busy, that the schedule does not allow for it — and I have felt it myself, many times. But the objection misunderstands what formation is. Formation is not an additional activity you add to the schedule; it is the character of the activities already in it. It is not thirty minutes of devotions bolted onto an otherwise secular day, but the way you are present in the day you already have. You are already forming your children every hour they are with you. The only question is in which direction.

I am not saying that teaching does not matter — it does, content matters, Scripture matters, doctrine matters. What I am saying is that teaching without formation produces a child who can defend a position they do not actually hold, and formation without teaching produces a child with a warm sense of spirituality and no structure to carry them

A child raised on formation without content is like a tree that grows strong but does not know its own species: it needs instruction, it needs to learn the name and shape of the thing it already is, and when that instruction comes it confirms what the child already knew in their bones. A child raised on content without formation is like a blueprint without a house — the plans are precise, the specs are correct, but nobody built anything; the child has all the information and no structure to live in, and when the wind comes, the blueprint shelters no one. Build the house. Let the blueprint serve the house. Let the formation come first, and let the content fill the space the formation has opened.

THE COMPARISON TRAP EVERY CHRISTIAN PARENT KNOWS

There is one thing I see in nearly every conversation I have with Christian parents about formation, and it is the comparison trap. You look at another family and see what appears to be a seamlessly formed household — the children are polite, they quote Scripture, they lead worship at youth group, the parents seem calm, the home seems ordered — and then you look at your own household, where the morning was chaos and the evening ended in tears and the Bible reading lasted four minutes before someone spilled milk on the table, and you think, we are

You are not failing. You are comparing your interior to their exterior, your Tuesday morning to their Sunday morning, your actual life to the curated version of theirs you are permitted to see — and the comparison is poisoning your ability to see what God is actually doing in your own home.

I have been inside both kinds of homes, the ones that look formed from the outside and the ones that feel chaotic from the inside, and from twenty years of pastoral observation I can tell you the correlation between external polish and internal formation is weaker than you think. Some of the most polished Christian families I have known produced children who walked away from the faith the moment they left home, because the formation was cosmetic — it was behavior management dressed in spiritual language. And some of the most chaotic, struggling, imperfect households I have known produced children whose faith is as deep as bedrock, because the formation was real: it was messy and inconsistent and often interrupted by spilled milk, but the center held, and the center was not the parents' competence — it was Christ, actually present, in the middle of the mess.

Stop comparing your home to the home that looks better from the outside, and start asking the questions that matter. Is Christ the center of this household, not in theory but in practice? Do my children see me turn to God when I am afraid? Do my children hear me pray when nothing is wrong? Do my children know that they are loved with a love that is not contingent on their performance? Those are the formation questions, and you can answer them honestly without looking at anyone else's home.

When my second son was eight, he asked me if God could make a rock so big that He could not lift it; he had heard the question somewhere and it fascinated him. I could have given him the standard philosophical answer about the logical coherence of omnipotence, and I did not. I said, that is a question philosophers have asked for a long time, and the short answer is that the question itself is built wrong, like asking if God can make a square circle — but here is what I want you to know: the fact that you are asking hard questions about God means your mind is working the way God designed it to work, so keep asking, and I will always try to answer, and when I cannot, we will look for the answer together. He does not remember that conversation. I remember it, because it was one of the

James K.A. Smith has spent a career arguing that we are not first thinking things but desiring, loving, liturgical animals, formed less by what we are taught than by what we are repeatedly made to love — and he is right, and the home is where the first liturgies are written. Your home is a formation space; it became one the day your child entered it, and the only question is what it is forming, with the answer to that question beginning in you, the parent, and the God you are actually walking with when no one is watching. Let us go into the rooms where that walking happens. The catechism room is first.

CHAPTER TWO

The Home Is the Primary Catechism

How the Christian home disciplines children every day — the rhythms, words, and habits that teach a child who God is before any lesson does.

There is an old word Christian parents should recover, and the word is catechism. Most Protestants have forgotten it, and the ones who keep it tend to treat it as a document — a book of questions and answers a child learns by repetition. That is one meaning, and it is not the deepest one. The deepest meaning is the shaping of a person, through the rhythms of teaching and life together, into what they believe at the level below argument. In that older and heavier sense, every home is a catechism. The only question is which one.

Your children are being catechized from the day they are born, and if they live in your home, you are the primary catechist — not the only one, but the first. The culture catechizes them, their friends catechize them, the algorithms they scroll through catechize them with a great

Let me be concrete, because this is the chapter where we start naming specifics. A household's catechism runs on four channels, all the time, whether you intend them or not: what the family praises, what the family worries about, what the family repeats, and what the family rests in. None of them announce themselves. All of them are teaching.

THE FOUR CHANNELS YOUR HOME DISCIPLES THROUGH

Children notice what their parents praise, and you can watch it happen — watch a child's eyes when a parent lights up, because in that moment the child is learning what is worth lighting up about. If the parent lights up about money, the child learns that money is the thing; if the parent lights up about academic performance, the child learns that performance is the thing; but if the parent lights up when the child is kind, when the child is honest, when the child is brave for the sake of someone weaker, the child learns something else entirely. I am not saying you should never celebrate a good grade. I am saying that the pattern of your celebration is teaching, day after day, and that your praise is itself a catechism.

I have watched this run in both directions. I knew a family in one of my earlier churches where the father was a successful businessman, and every achievement the

I knew another family where the mother praised character. When her daughter told the truth about something that would have been easier to hide, the mother stopped what she was doing, knelt to the girl's level, and said, that is the kind of person God is making you into, and I am proud of you. That was not a formula; it was a reflex — and the reflex catechized the child, day after day, in a theology that had nothing to do with output and everything to do with who she was becoming. That girl is in her late twenties now, still walking with Jesus, and she will tell you that her mother's voice is still the loudest in the room when she has to make a hard decision.

Children also read what their parents worry about, and they are more attuned to parental anxiety than parents ever realize. A child knows when you are stressed about the mortgage even if you have never said the word in front of them; a child knows when you are anxious about a social situation, when you fear a particular person's opinion, when you are quietly obsessed with how your life

Here is what worry actually catechizes: it catechizes the nature of God. A worried household teaches, at the catechism level and below argument, that God is not trustworthy, that the world is finally in the hands of forces God cannot control, that the parent must grip tighter because letting go is too dangerous. A child raised in that home may learn all the right verses about trusting God — and they will believe the worry, because the worry was the catechism that ran all day and the verses were the correction that ran for fifteen minutes at bedtime.

This does not mean you must never worry. It means you must bring the worry somewhere your children can see. When you are afraid and you take that fear to God out loud, in the kitchen, where your child can hear you say, Lord, I am anxious about this, and I am bringing it to You because I cannot carry it — you are catechizing your child in the nature of God, teaching them below argument that there is a Father who receives fear and does something with it. That catechism will run longer and louder than the anxiety, if you practice it.

Children remember what the family repeats — not what it says once, but what it says a thousand times: the prayer

James K. A. Smith calls these liturgies, and the word is exactly right, because a liturgy is a repeated practice that forms desire, and the church has understood this for two thousand years. When you pray the Lord's Prayer weekly, you are not delivering information; you are forming a people whose desires are being shaped by the prayer even when they are not paying full attention. The same thing happens in a home: when you speak a blessing over your children before bed, you are forming a child whose sense of identity is shaped by the blessing even when they are half asleep; when you sing the same hymn in the car on the way to church, you are forming their emotional association with worship before they understand what worship is.

The danger of repetition is that it goes empty — the grace before meals that nobody means, the bedtime prayer recited with the parent's foot already out the door. Children know when the repetition has gone hollow, and they are not fooled by it; they are catechized by it, and what they learn from hollow repetition is that the words do not matter, that the rituals are performances, that the

And children learn what is trustworthy by watching what their parents rest in. When the parent is exhausted, what does the parent turn to; when the parent is afraid, what does the parent reach for; when the parent needs comfort, where does the parent go. Children are not fooled by stated values, so they watch the parent's rest, because rest reveals the true god of a household. If the parent rests in scrolling, in wine, in the next purchase, in the praise of a certain person, the child receives a theology of rest; if the parent rests in prayer, in the presence of God, in Scripture, in the company of people who genuinely love them, the child receives a different one.

*A household's resting point tells you
more about its actual theology than its
stated theology ever will.*

I want to press here, because this is the most revealing of the four. The parent who collapses into a screen every evening is not bad; they are tired. But the child is watching

So a household catechism is built from four materials — what you praise, what you worry about, what you repeat, what you rest in — and the child is writing a book inside them whose chapters are constructed from those four. The book the child finishes is the book they will carry into adulthood.

THE TWO CATECHISMS FORMING YOUR CHILD

Most Christian parents have tried to add content to the catechism without ever touching the four channels. They sit their children down for devotions at seven in the evening while the household runs all day on anxiety, appearance, and performance, and the child receives a mixed signal: Mom praises grades and mentions Jesus, Dad worries about work and says God is in control, the family repeats platitudes the family does not live and rests in the phone, and then at seven everyone opens a Bible together for fifteen minutes. The children receive the data, but the catechism has already been written.

This is why so many adults leave the faith of their childhood and say they do not know why. They know why. They were catechized by a household running two catechisms at once — one explicit, one implicit; the explicit

I have seen this in my own home. There was a period, several years ago, when Susanna and I were running hard: ministry was demanding, the boys were at ages where everything required logistics, and we were physically present and spiritually depleted. We kept doing the family devotional, we kept saying the prayers, but the boys could tell something had changed — not in the devotional, in us. We were more irritable, more distracted, quicker to snap and slower to repair, and the implicit catechism was quietly drowning the explicit one. Our oldest, who has a gift for directness I suspect he got from me, said one night at dinner: you guys seem different lately, not bad, tired. That was the kindest version of what he could have said. What he meant was: the thing you say is real does not seem to be reaching you right now, and I can tell.

That was a turning point. The next week Susanna and I made a decision that changed more in our home than any curriculum ever could — we would tend our own souls first, before the family devotional, before the children's ministry, before the church calendar, getting our own lives with God back into a sustainable, honest place. We started praying together again, as a couple, not for the family but for ourselves; we started reading Scripture again, not to prepare for anything but to be near God. And as that happened, the four channels began to shift — not because

READING YOUR OWN HOUSE: WHAT IT TEACHES ABOUT GOD

A parent can rewrite the household catechism, slowly, not by adding a program but by paying attention to the four channels and beginning to align them with the thing the household says it believes. The first work is honesty about what the house is currently teaching, and that work startles you. When I sat down and watched my own four channels for a week, I found that I praised achievement far more than character; that I worried aloud about money and time more than I trusted aloud in God's provision; that the phrases I repeated most were hurry up and not now and we will talk about it later; and that when I was spent at the end of the day, I reached for the screen before I reached for anything else. None of that was what I would have said my household catechism was. It was what it was.

Susanna and I sat with that for a while, and we did not overhaul the household overnight; we chose one channel at a time. We started with praise, deciding that every day, at least once, we would name character in front of the boys rather than performance — when one of them was kind, when one of them was honest, when one of them was brave in a moment where silence would have been easier. That one shift, sustained over months, changed the feel of the house. Not a new program. A channel that had been running on autopilot, turned on purpose.

Worry was harder, because worry is reflexive — you do not decide to worry aloud, it escapes. But when one of us caught ourselves worrying in front of the boys, we learned

Repetition was the easiest to change, because it was the most concrete, so we chose phrases we wanted to become load-bearing — the blessing over the boys before bed, the old words from Numbers:

■ *The Lord bless you and keep you.*

— NUMBERS 6:24

There was a question at dinner, where did you see God today — not every night, but often enough that they expected it — and a sentence Susanna began saying to each boy in the morning, God has a plan for you today. These repetitions, sustained over years, are embedded in my sons now, and they will carry those phrases into their own households one day whether they know it or not. That is catechism.

Rest is the channel we are still working on, and it is the hardest, because it touches the deepest part of us. Where do I go when I am depleted — if the honest answer is the phone, the television, or the pantry, then that is what my children are learning is the resting place. Changing that answer requires me to change myself, and that is the deepest work of all.

THE CATECHISM THAT GROWS

I noticed this when our boys hit adolescence, and the practices that had worked when they were small — the bedtime blessing, the dinner question, the Saturday morning Scripture reading — began to feel different. Not wrong. Different. The boys were changing; their capacity for depth was growing while their tolerance for routine was shrinking, so we made changes. The bedtime blessing stayed, because it was non-negotiable in our house, but it got shorter and more personal, one sentence tailored to what that boy was carrying that day. The dinner question moved from where did you see God today to something more probing — what was the hardest thing about today, what are you afraid of right now, what made you angry this week — and those opened doors the simpler question had stopped opening. And the Saturday reading became a conversation: I stopped reading to them and started reading with them, asking what they thought, letting them disagree, letting the text be alive rather than recited.

The four channels are permanent — what you praise, what you worry about, what you repeat, what you rest in, those run for the life of the household — but the content that flows through them must mature. I have seen families lose their teenagers because the parents refused to let it, because the practices that formed the children at six were

THE HOUSE THAT IMPLICATES YOU

The reason most parents resist all of this is that it implicates the parent. You cannot change what the household praises without changing what you praise; you cannot change what it worries about without changing what you worry about; you cannot change what it rests in without changing where you go for rest. Every channel reveals the interior life of the adults, and that is the thing most of us do not want revealed.

The house will catechize the child either way; the only question is whether it catechizes them toward Christ or away from Him — and that is not a question of content but a question of alignment, one that points inward before it points outward. I am not writing as a man who has nailed this. I am writing as a man who has been confronted, again and again, with the gap between the catechism my sons say we have and the catechism my weekly life actually teaches them. When the gap narrows, formation follows; when it widens, nothing I say from a pulpit can fix it, and nothing a Sunday school teacher says can fix it either.

The household is the first and most honest seminary a Christian will ever attend, and most of us graduated before we could speak. It is worth asking, slowly, what the

The next chapter is for the parents who read that and thought: that is the church's job. I want to answer that one directly.

CHAPTER THREE

When the Church Replaces the Parent

*Why Sunday school, youth group, and children's
ministry cannot form a child's faith alone — and
how parents become the primary disciple-
makers again.*

I am a pastor; I lead a local church, and I have given my adult life to a particular congregation in a small Michigan town because I love what gathers there. I say all of that first because of what I am about to argue: that if you have handed the spiritual formation of your children to the church you attend, you have made a quiet mistake — and that the church, for its part, has too often been happy to receive what it was never built to carry.

Over the last fifty years, American evangelicalism restructured itself on a single assumption, that the spiritual formation of children is primarily the church's job, and then it built an entire infrastructure to do that job — age-graded Sunday school, children's church, Vacation Bible School, Awana, mid-week kids programs, youth

I watch parents do exactly this every week. They drop off a kindergartner on Sunday morning like a dry-cleaning ticket, pick up a fifth grader at the end of Wednesday night Awana and ask only what he earned, and sign a youth-retreat permission slip without ever once asking what the retreat is covering — investing in their children's spiritual life by paying the registration fees and running the carpool. And when those same children hit eighteen, twenty, twenty-two and step away from the faith, the parents are devastated, and they ask what they did wrong. The honest answer is the hard one. You did everything you were told to do; what you were told to do was never going to produce what you were hoping for.

HOW PARENTS BECAME THE CHURCH'S DELIVERY SYSTEM

This did not happen by accident. The explosion of children's and youth ministry in the second half of the twentieth century was driven by good intentions running alongside market logic: the good intention was to reach young people with the gospel, and the market logic held that specialized, age-appropriate programming would do this better than general worship services. Both are partially true — young people do need to hear the gospel in language they can receive, and age-appropriate teaching does have value. But the market logic carried an

Consider what that arrangement communicated to the average Christian parent across three full generations: that spiritual formation is specialized work; that it requires training the parent does not have; that the parent's role is logistical rather than formational. Get the child to the program, the message ran, and the program will do the work — the parent supporting the program by volunteering, by giving, by reinforcing at home what the program already teaches. The program sat at the center, and the parent was reassigned to the support staff.

That is backwards, and it has always been backwards. We are now living in the wreckage of a fifty-year experiment that proved it, because the generation formed primarily in church programs rather than in homes is the very generation leaving the faith at historically unprecedented rates — not because the programs were bad, but because the programs were carrying a weight they were never designed to carry. A youth pastor with forty students, two hours a week, and a six-year window cannot undo or redirect sixteen years of whatever the home has been quietly teaching. The math does not work. It never did.

THE MATH NO ONE DOES: CHURCH HOURS VS HOME HOURS

Here is the math most Christian parents have never sat down to do. Add up every hour a child spends in church

That sounds like a great deal until you work the other side of the equation and ask how many hours a child is in the home from birth to eighteen — not merely present in the house, but awake and in proximity to a parent. Call it thirty-five thousand hours on the low end, and realistically more. A well-attended child is receiving roughly ten times as much formation at home as at church, which is not a comparison so much as a structural reality: the home is the main event, and the church is a complement to it, never a replacement for it.

Most of you already know this in your bones; the problem is that you have been trained out of acting on it. You have been led, patiently, over years, to believe you are not qualified — that the qualified people are the youth pastor, the children's director, the small group leader, the curriculum writer, and that you are merely a parent whose task is to hand your children to the qualified people so the qualified people can form them. That is the model, and it is a bad one, because it assumes the child forms primarily in programmatic environments rather than in the ordinary, unglamorous weight of a home.

I want to name what I have seen from the pastoral side, because parents rarely get to see it. Year after year I have

I have watched youth pastors absorb the blame, too, when a student walked away — the parents looking hard at the youth pastor, the youth pastor looking back at the parents, and neither of them saying the true thing aloud: that the student's faith had been eroding at home for years, that the youth group had been the one place it was still alive, and that when the student finally left the group the faith left with it, because it had no roots anywhere outside the program. The program had been the faith. The home had been something else.

THE CHURCH AS PARTNER, NOT VENDOR

The church is not the primary catechist of your child. The church is the assembly of believers — including you — gathered around word and sacrament and mission, and your child genuinely belongs in that assembly, learns from it, and is shaped by it. But the assembly is not a parenting replacement; it is a parenting context. The congregation is the extended family within which you do the primary work, not the contractor you hired to do that work on your behalf.

The second thing that changes is that parents begin to see the church not as a vendor but as a partner — bringing their children into the life of the congregation not to outsource but to reinforce what is already happening at home. You want them near other believing adults, not because you are delegating the teaching, but because you want them to see that your house is not the only house where Christ is Lord; you want them in a room with other people singing, so they hear that your faith is not some private family quirk; you want them around older believers, because your mother-in-law has walked with God for forty years and you have walked with Him for eight, and the older saints are a gift your household can borrow from. You are not outsourcing. You are integrating.

The church, in other words, is the community in which your home's catechism is confirmed. Your child hears you

*Stop treating the youth group as the
load-bearing wall of your child's
faith. It is not. Your home is.*

FAITH IS NOT A DEPARTMENT

I want to be careful here, because I have no wish to swing too far the other way. There is a family-worship subculture that has overcorrected against the outsourcing model by pulling children out of age-graded ministry entirely, keeping them in the adult service, running rigorous family devotions, and treating the programmatic side of the church as unnecessary or even corrupting — a subculture that has correctly named a real problem and then answered it with a posture that sometimes hardens into

If your home is teaching a true faith and the children are forming near it, a mediocre youth group will not undo that — I have seen it with my own eyes, kids whose youth group was not much and whose parents were quietly serious about Jesus, and those kids grew into men and women whose faith went the distance. I have also seen the exact opposite: top-shelf youth ministry, engaging teaching, great relationships, and parents whose actual life at home communicated that God is not really the center. Those kids aged out of the youth group, and the faith did not stick, because the youth group had been carrying a load the home refused to carry. The youth group cannot win that fight. Nothing can win it except a change at home.

There is one more thing the outsourcing model quietly does to children, and it is rarely discussed: it teaches them that faith is compartmentalized — something that happens in certain buildings, with certain people, at certain times, while the rest of life is something else entirely. Church is church, home is home, school is school, and faith lives in the church compartment; so when the child eventually leaves that compartment, the faith stays behind, like a coat left hanging in a closet. The child has learned, through the very structure of the model, that faith is not integrated into ordinary life. It is a department. And departments can be closed.

A home doing its own formation work teaches the opposite. Faith is not a department; it is the operating

THE COSTLY HOPE

You get back what you were told you could give away. You are the primary catechist of your children, and you do not need a degree or a curriculum certification to be it — you need a life with Christ, the willingness to let your children see that life up close, and the maturity to bring them into the life of a congregation where that shared life is reinforced and expanded. That is a weight, and it does not feel like relief; it feels, instead, like the responsibility you thought you had safely handed off has quietly landed back on your own shoulders.

It has. Because it was always there, and it was never the church's to take. The church's role is to come alongside you — to preach the word to the whole household, to teach your children in ways that complement what you are already teaching, to surround you with other families trying to do the same difficult thing. The church is there for the help you cannot provide alone. It is not there to do what only a parent can do.

If you are a pastor or a children's worker reading this, you already know what I am saying is true. You have been sold to parents as a service, and you have sometimes believed the sales copy; but you have also watched families

You cannot do their parents' job; you can only do your own, which is to come alongside the parent — to equip them, encourage them, love them, and serve their children as a partner in what the parent is primarily carrying. Your job is not to be the parent, and it never was; when you try, both of you lose, and the child loses worst of all. The church we have built often incentivizes the outsourcing anyway, because it is easier to run a program than to challenge a household, and because a child at every event looks, on the annual report, like an engaged family. We should be measuring formation, not attendance. I am not asking us to dismantle children's ministry. I am asking us to reorient it toward the household, in service of the parents, as a supplement to the life a family is already living rather than a substitute for the life it is not.

WHAT YOU CAN DO AT HOME TONIGHT

I know that many parents reading this are now feeling the guilt rise — you have been dropping your children at church programs and hoping the programs would do the work, and now the weight of it is settling in. Here is what I want to say to that guilt: do not stay there. Guilt that produces change is useful; guilt that produces paralysis is not. If this chapter has shown you something about your household that needs to change, then change it, and do not

Tonight you can sit at the table and ask your children a real question; tonight you can pray out loud in a room where they can hear you; tonight you can say the blessing over them before bed; tonight you can turn off the television and read a passage of Scripture — not because you are performing a devotional, but because you want to be near God and you want them to see you wanting it. Those are small things, and they are also the entire argument of this book: small things, done consistently, in a household where the adults are actually walking with Christ, over years, in ordinary rooms. That is the curriculum. You already have everything you need to start it tonight.



These words that I command you today shall be on your heart. You shall teach them diligently to your children, and shall talk of them when you sit in your house, and when you walk by the way, and when you lie down, and when you rise.

— DEUTERONOMY 6:6-7

The church gives community, corporate worship, teaching from many voices, the experience of belonging to something larger than one family; the parent gives proximity, daily formation, honest answers, emotional safety, and the lived demonstration of what it looks like to follow Jesus when nobody is watching. Together those two forces produce a formed child, and apart each is incomplete — the church without the home producing a child who knows about God but has no lived reference for walking with Him in the ordinary, the home without the

So this is the chapter where we stop pretending the church is where this happens. The church is where it is reinforced, celebrated, expanded, and held in common with other families; where it happens, primarily, is the place no one else can see, where the parent is the one being watched. That is your house. That is your Tuesday at six thirty in the evening. That is the fifteen minutes before your children go to bed. The goal is not to pull your child out of church programs — it is to make sure that when your child walks through those doors on Sunday morning, he walks in from a household where the faith is already alive, and not from a household where the faith is on hold until the professionals take over.

Now we turn to what those children are quietly asking while they watch you.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Questions Children Actually Ask

How to answer the hard questions kids ask about

*God — death, suffering, other religions, and
doubt — so your home stays the safe place to ask.*

Somewhere around age eight, sometimes earlier, a child begins to ask the real questions, and they almost never arrive when you are ready for them — they come in the back of the car, at the dinner table when the conversation was about something else entirely, in the last minute before sleep when the child has worked out that a parent cannot easily walk away. They are plain on the surface and devastating underneath. If God is good, why did my dog die. If God is real, why did grandma die. Is heaven real. What if I do not feel like I love Jesus. Why are there other religions, and how do we know the Bible is true, and why do bad people seem to win, and what happens to my friend who does not believe.

How a parent answers in the first ninety seconds tells the child everything — not about the answer, but about

Most of us answer too quickly, reaching for a phrase half remembered from a sermon, or a verse that does not quite fit, or some version of because God said so; we change the subject, we try to shut the question down before it unsettles us, and worse — through tone, through impatience, through the sheer speed of the response — we tell the child that the question itself is the problem. That Christians do not ask this. That faithful children do not doubt. That curiosity is a temptation to be resisted rather than a door to be walked through together.

When we do that, we teach the child something far more damaging than the content of our too-quick answer: we teach them that questions do not belong in this household, and the child learns very early that if there is a question underneath the belief, it has to be hidden from the adults. And because children are not stupid, they keep asking — they just stop asking you. They ask Google, they ask their friends, they ask the algorithm quietly curating the videos they fall asleep to, they ask at two in the morning to themselves, and they build, over years, a parallel life of unresolved doubt that runs alongside their polite church attendance.

The mechanism matters, so trace it slowly. A child asks a question, and the parent's response opens one of two doors. Behind the first, the question is received: the parent's face is open, the parent does not rush, and the child learns that this house is a place where I can think about God honestly — the question gets discussed over days or weeks, and the child absorbs not only the content but the posture, that faith and questions live in the same

Behind the second door, the question is deflected — the parent's face is tight, the answer comes too fast, and the child learns that this house is not a place where I can think about God honestly. The question goes underground, and the child learns to perform belief while conducting the real intellectual life elsewhere.

The second door is the one producing the crisis we are in: a generation of young adults raised in Christian homes who will tell you, if you ask, that their first honest conversation about faith happened in college — not because their parents were bad people, but because their parents could not handle the questions, and the children, being loyal, stopped asking.

Eventually one of two things happens. They hit an age, usually between sixteen and twenty-two, when the parallel life overwhelms the church one and they walk away; or they keep performing belief while no longer holding it, because they do not want to disappoint the people who clearly could not bear their doubt. Neither outcome is faith. Both are the result of households that could not tolerate a child's honest question.

So reframe it. A child asking you a hard spiritual question is not drifting from faith — often they are doing the exact opposite, trying to make their faith fit the reality they are seeing, and that is a sign of spiritual seriousness, not spiritual weakness. The child who never asks is not the child who has settled faith; the child who never asks is often the child whose curiosity has already migrated elsewhere because the home did not feel safe for it. So when your child asks you a hard question, be grateful — it means they still trust you with it. Do not blow that trust by

THREE QUESTIONS KIDS ASK THAT ARE REALLY A THEOLOGY

Here is what I have learned raising five sons and pastoring for twenty years: three sentences will carry you through almost every hard question your child asks — if you mean them, and if you have the courage to say them slowly.

First, that is a really good question — not as filler, but as an honest response, because the question really is a good one and you are welcoming it before you answer it. The child is watching your face while you say it, and everything hangs on what your face does: if it is honest, the conversation breathes; if it is tight, the child already knows this was a mistake.

Second, I have wondered that too — said only if it is true, and in my experience it will almost always be true, because children ask the questions grown adults ask quietly. If you are a Christian who has never wondered whether God is real, whether suffering makes sense, whether other religions might be right, whether the Bible can be trusted, then you are either lying to your child or you are not yet a mature believer; mature faith has sat with hard questions and come through them to confidence, which is a different thing altogether from never having had the questions. When you tell your child you have wondered what they are wondering, you hand them a gift — you tell them doubt is part of faith, not the opposite of it, and you tell them they are not broken for asking.

Third, let us think about it together — not here is the answer, but let us think. That language is slow on purpose. It refuses to perform certainty, it models a believing mind

Those three sentences work because they are not a technique. They are a theology. The first says your question has dignity; the second says your doubt is human, not sinful; the third says we find truth together, not by decree. All three are theologically loaded, and a Christianity that cannot say them to a child is a Christianity that does not trust its own claims enough to let them be examined — and a Christianity that does not trust its own claims will never convince a child who is watching to see whether the adults actually believe what they say.

*Your authority does not come from
answering every question in real time.
It comes from a God you trust with the
things you cannot answer — and a
child watching you do it.*

THE HARD BIBLE QUESTIONS A PARENT CANNOT ANSWER

I cannot count the times one of my sons has asked me a question I could not answer well in the moment. A few

What I had was the three sentences. That is a really good question. I have wondered that too. Let us think about it together. And then I told him the truth — that I do not think there is a tidy answer, that Christians have wrestled with this passage for two thousand years, that I hold a tentative way of understanding it, and that I wanted to walk through it with him over the coming weeks. So we came back to it, more than once; we read some commentators together; I did not resolve it for him but let him stay with it, with me. That is what formation looks like on a hard question.

Here is what I did not do. I did not pretend I had a clean answer, I did not give him a Sunday school platitude, I did not fast-talk past the difficulty, I did not act as though the question itself were unfaithful — and I did not walk away feeling like a failure because I had not converted his question into certainty on my own timeline.

WHEN THE QUESTION IS NOT REALLY ABOUT INFORMATION

There is another kind of question entirely, and it asks for a different posture, because it is not really about information at all — it is about pain. A child whose grandfather has died asks if grandpa is in heaven, and he



*The Lord is near to the brokenhearted and saves the
crushed in spirit.*

— PSALM 34:18

The parent who answers the emotional question with an intellectual answer has missed the child entirely, because the child needed a hug first, and tears, and to hear that grief is okay and that God is near to the brokenhearted. The theology can come later. The presence comes first.

I have made this mistake — I have answered emotional questions with theological precision when what my son needed was his father's arms and his father's honesty, that death is painful, that we grieve with hope but the grief is real and we do not have to pretend it is not. The child who receives a lecture when he needed a human presence learns that faith is cold, which is not what we mean to teach; it is what we teach anyway when we reach for our head before we reach for our heart.

Name the most common mistake, which is believing that every hard question requires an immediate settled answer or you have lost your authority. Not true. Your authority does not come from answering every theological question in real time — it comes from your presence, your integrity, your faithfulness over years, and the plain reality that you love your child. You can hold an unresolved question in front of your child for a whole season and

There is a subtler mistake, and it is harder to see — answering a question the child did not ask because the question the child did ask scares us. A child asks about hell and we turn it into a lesson on sin; a child asks why a relative died and we turn it into a platitude about heaven; in each case we are answering our own discomfort rather than the child's actual question. Children can tell. They learn not to ask.

One category terrifies many Christian parents above the rest: questions about other religions and other worldviews. A child comes home and says her friend is Muslim, or Hindu, or atheist, and wants to know why the friend believes something different and whether the friend is wrong — and this terrifies the parent who has been taught that exposure to other worldviews is dangerous. But the question is not dangerous. The question is the beginning of apologetics.



Always be prepared to give an answer to everyone who asks you to give the reason for the hope that you have. But do this with gentleness and respect.

— 1 PETER 3:15

The child is asking you to give a reason for the hope that is in you, and if you cannot do it with gentleness and respect, as Peter commanded, the child will conclude that your faith cannot withstand comparison. That conclusion

So answer the actual question. If you do not know, say so; if it is complicated, say so; if there is more than one Christian position, name it, because you are not required to pretend the tradition is monolithic. Children are impressed, not destabilized, by a parent who says there are faithful Christians who read this passage differently, and here is how your mother and I see it and why — you are giving them a model of thinking, and you are giving them permission to think, which most of them are already doing anyway.

WHAT FIFTEEN YEARS OF OPEN DOORS PRODUCES

I have watched what happens when a household handles questions well over years, and the child raised in a home where questions are welcome does not stop asking — they ask better ones. At eight it is why did the dog die; at twelve, how do we know the resurrection happened; at sixteen, what do we do about suffering in the world; at nineteen, how do I hold my faith when my roommate's arguments are good. The progression is striking when the door has stayed open, because at every stage the child's faith is being refined by the questions rather than eroded by them.

The questions do to faith what fire does to gold: they burn away what is false and leave what is true. A child whose questions have been welcomed for fifteen years has a faith that has been tested, and a tested faith is a faith that lasts.

I have also watched the opposite. The child raised

So build question-asking into the rhythms of the household, and do not wait for questions to surface at random — make spaces where they are expected. At the dinner table, ask what your children are thinking about, not what they learned at school but what they are thinking about; at bedtime, after the prayer, ask if there is anything they have been wondering about; on car rides, turn off the music for ten minutes and ask. You will get silence at first, and shrugs, but keep asking, because over weeks and months the child begins to believe you mean it — and when they believe you mean it, the questions come. They come to you, which is the whole point.

START NOW, WHILE THE QUESTIONS ARE STILL SMALL

The hope in this chapter is plain and heavy: be the safe person your child can ask the hardest question of their life now, so that ten years from now, when the question is the one that will decide whether they stay in the faith, they are still coming to you with it. Not to Google. Not to the friend who is also confused. To you.

Some of you are parents of teenagers who have already stopped asking; you feel the loss, you know when the questions went underground, and you wonder if it is too late. It is not too late. But you will have to begin by being honest — that you know you did not handle their questions well when they were smaller, and that you want to try again. You might get silence, you might get an eye roll, you might get a door opening slowly over months; do not rush it, and do not retaliate against the slowness, because a parent willing to earn back the conversation, who does not demand it or grow bitter when it is slow in coming, is a parent doing holy work. Keep doing it.

Your children have questions, thousands of them, and most of them do not yet know what those questions will grow into. You cannot give them certainty. But you can give them a seat at your table while they work it out, with a Bible open between you and the Holy Spirit doing what He does best, which is drawing people to Christ in the slow and honest way.

The questions children ask change as they grow, and the parent who handles a six-year-old well can be caught off guard by a twelve-year-old. Young children ask concrete questions — where is heaven, what does God look like, can God see me in the dark — questions that are spatial, physical, imagination-level, because they are trying to locate God in the world they can see. The parent's job here is to be concrete in return: God is everywhere, but

Older children ask moral questions — why did God let the dog die, why are there poor people if God loves everyone, why did my friend's parents divorce — and these are justice questions, the questions of a child developing a moral sense and testing whether God fits inside it. The parent who answers with theological precision but no emotional engagement loses the child's trust, because the child is not asking for a theodicy lecture; the child is asking whether God is good in a world that does not always look good. So hold both truths together: the world is broken, and the breaking causes real pain, and God is in the middle of the pain doing something about it even when we cannot see what He is doing. That answer is not neat. It is honest. And honest answers at this stage lay a foundation for the harder questions coming.

Teenagers ask identity questions — how do I know God is real and not just something I believe because my parents do, why should the Bible have authority over my life when other smart people call it mythology, what makes Christianity different from any other religion that claims to be true — and these are existential questions. The teenager is not trying to be difficult; the teenager is trying to own their beliefs rather than borrow yours, and the parent who reacts with fear or anger only confirms the teenager's suspicion that the faith cannot survive examination.

I have seen parents panic at this stage, hearing their

THE YEAR MY SON QUESTIONED HIS FAITH

The better response is to welcome the question and honor the questioner. When my son asked me, at fourteen, how he could know God was real and not just something he believed because his father was a pastor, I felt pride before I felt anything else — because that question meant he was doing the work. He was not content to carry a borrowed faith. He wanted his own. And getting his own required testing the one he had been given.

I told him several things: that his question was one of the best a person can ask, and that I was glad he was asking it; that I had asked the same question when I was not much older than him, and that my faith had survived the asking; that there are good reasons to believe God is real and Christianity true, reasons articulated by some of the brightest minds in human history, and that I would gladly walk through some of them with him; and that faith is not the absence of doubt but trust in the face of doubt, because the God of the Bible is not threatened by honest

We spent the next several months reading together, and not the Bible at first. We read parts of C. S. Lewis, we read parts of Tim Keller, we watched some lectures, we talked about what he found persuasive and what he did not — and somewhere in those months, something shifted. He moved from testing a borrowed faith to building his own. The content was much the same; the ownership was different. And that difference is everything.

Some questions come without words. A child who starts lying is asking a question about safety — am I safe to tell the truth in this house, or will the truth get me hurt; a child who starts withdrawing is asking about belonging — do I still belong here if I am not who you want me to be; a child who starts acting out is asking about attention — does anyone in this house notice me when I am not performing.

These behavioral questions are harder to hear than spoken ones, because the behavior triggers the parent's frustration rather than their curiosity: the parent sees the lie and responds to the lie, sees the withdrawal and takes it personally, sees the acting out and reaches for discipline, and in each case the parent is answering the surface behavior rather than the question underneath it.

The parent who can look past the behavior to the question is the parent who can actually form the child — which does not mean the behavior goes unaddressed, but that the behavior is addressed after the question has been heard. You lied to me, and we need to talk about that; but first I want to understand something — are you afraid of what happens when you tell me the truth, because if you are, that is something I need to change about how I respond to you. That kind of response forms a child. It

Underneath all of this lies another issue — one that shapes whether the child is even asking for truth or asking for permission. That is the next chapter. Obedience without gospel.

CHAPTER FIVE

Obedience Without Gospel

How behavior-first Christian parenting raises children who walk away — and why grace, not compliance, has to come before the command.

There is a particular brand of Christian parenting that raises atheists, and it does not mean to — it comes from parents who love their children and believe they are doing the most serious work of their lives, which they are, except that they are running the wrong version of it. The version produces a child who behaves well, checks the right boxes, gives the parent no trouble, and then somewhere around age twenty quietly concludes that the whole thing was about compliance and that he has outgrown it.

Name it. The version is obedience without gospel, and it treats the Christian life as a set of behaviors the child must perform: do not do this, do this, memorize these verses, avoid those people, stay in church, off the phone, dressed a certain way, speaking a certain way. The content of the rules varies by tribe, but the logic underneath is

This model carries two problems, and they run deep. The first is that it is not the gospel at all but moralism wearing Christian vocabulary; the second is that even when it works, even when it delivers exactly the child it promises, it produces the wrong kind of person — because the point of the Christian life was never a well-behaved child but a child whose heart has been confronted with the love of God and has learned to love God back. Behavior flows out of that. Behavior engineered without it is a hollow performance that holds until adolescence and then breaks.

If you get the behavior without the heart, you have not succeeded; you have only delayed a crisis, and it comes, usually when the child is old enough to resent a control he cannot remember agreeing to. When it comes, understand what is actually happening: he is not throwing away a relationship with Jesus, because he never had one. He was performing a relationship with his parents, and the moment he could get out from under that performance, he did — and he was right to, because the performance was never the real thing.

TWO KINDS OF OBEDIENCE IN CHRISTIAN KIDS

Many parents running this model do not know they are running it; they think they are teaching their children the

Consider what happens when a child lies to a parent. The moralist parent responds along one line: lying is a sin, God does not like it, you will be punished, do not do it again. The gospel parent starts somewhere else entirely — first the relationship, I love you, you are safe here; then the truth, what you did was wrong, and lying hurts people, including you; and then the gospel, which is that the reason we tell the truth in this house is not to avoid punishment but that God made you for truth, loved you enough to tell you the truth about yourself even the hard parts, and is making you into someone who can carry it. The correction is real and the consequence may be real, but the frame around it is grace and identity rather than fear and compliance.

The child raised on the first version learns that God is a rule enforcer who must be obeyed or else; the child raised on the second learns that God is a father who loves him and is forming him — and the obedience that flows from the second is a different species than the first. Fear-driven obedience expires the moment the enforcer is removed, while love-driven obedience deepens the moment the person is alone, because it is internally held rather than externally coerced.

I see the fruit of this in my pastoral work constantly. A couple comes to me grieving a grown child who has walked away, and the story is always the same in its outline — we raised him in the church, we had family devotions, he was respectful, well-behaved, a good student, he went on mission trips, and then he got to college and something

I have sat with enough of these parents to see the pattern clearly: they can name every program the child attended, they can name the baptism date and the commitment card from camp, but they cannot name the last time the child was met by God in a way the parent did not manage. And that is the whole tragedy in a sentence — because the child's entire spiritual life was supervised and directed, he never owned it; it belonged to the parent, and when the parent was no longer in the room, the faith was no longer in the room either.

THE GOSPEL: GOOD NEWS BEFORE COMMAND

Reframe it. The gospel is not a set of behaviors but the announcement that God has acted in Christ to rescue people who cannot rescue themselves — it is news before it is command. The commands follow. They do not precede. They do not substitute.

The moral life of a Christian is a response to the news, lived out of the power the news releases, which is the Holy Spirit at work in a heart brought into relationship with God through Christ — and that is the order: news first, then relationship, then changed behavior, never the reverse. Reverse it, which is exactly what much of American Christian parenting does, and you produce a child who has never heard good news at all, only demand. He has heard

I need to name something hard. The moralist model is attractive precisely because it produces visible, measurable results — a well-behaved child is a relief, a compliant child is socially acceptable, and a child who never questions, never pushes back, never makes a scene is one the parent can point to as evidence of good parenting. The model gives the parent what the parent wants, which is a child who makes the parent look good, and that is not formation but reputation management. And the child can feel the difference, even when he cannot name it, between a parent who wants him to be good and a parent who wants him to know God.

Compliance and formation are not the same thing. Sometimes they overlap. Sometimes they do not. The only way to know is to look at the heart, and the heart is not visible in behavior alone.

Your child's obedience is not the measure of your

GRACE HAS THE FIRST WORD

Here is what gospel parenting looks like in practice. When your child fails, which will happen every day, the first word out of your mouth is not correction but grace — which does not mean no correction, because correction comes, but it comes inside a frame that says nothing you can do will make me love you more, and nothing you can do will make me love you less. You are secure here. And so is the case with God.

He loves you, and He is not waiting for you to get it right before He loves you; He loves you enough to do the slow work of forming you into someone whose heart actually wants what He wants. That is the direction we are going — not perfect behavior but a formed heart, and everything we do in this house is bent toward that.

Your children will test whether you mean it. They will do the things that trigger your moralism, the things that expose whether your first instinct is control or grace, and

Your children also need to hear the gospel for themselves, personally, often — not a sermon but a sentence: you are loved by the Father, Jesus came for you, the cross is for your sin specifically, the Holy Spirit is with you, actually. Say these things, and name your child by name. Caleb, God loves you. Say it because it is true and because they need to hear it from a parent's mouth, for the child whose parent has spoken the gospel over him by name, hundreds of times across years, has something in his marrow that the child who only heard it in Sunday school does not have.

THE COST OF TRUSTING THE SILENCE

Do not over-correct the other way. I have seen parents react against moralism by removing all structure, all correction, all expectation — and that is not gospel parenting but permissive parenting with Christian language. Gospel parenting has real correction, real

The gospel does not remove the law; it fulfills it, and in fulfilling it changes why we obey — we do not obey to be loved, we obey because we are loved. The structure in your home remains while the source of the structure changes: it is not earning but responding. Your children need to see a home where the rules make sense because of who God is and what He has done, not because mom and dad demand it, and if you cannot answer the question why in your own rules at a level deeper than because I said so, then your rules are not formation but control — and control produces the very rebellion you feared, the moment your children are old enough to notice that the emperor has no theology.

I practiced this with one of my sons when he was eleven. He had read the Bible nightly with me since he was old enough to sit still, and then one week he said he did not want to — he said it was boring, that he did not see the point. My instinct was to lecture him about the importance of Scripture, which is moralism dressed up as discipleship; instead I said, I hear you, reading the Bible can feel boring, it has felt boring to me too, I am not going to make you read tonight, but I am going to keep reading, and if you want to talk about what I am reading, I am here. He did not read for three weeks. On the fourth week he sat down next to me while I was reading and asked what the passage was about, we talked for thirty minutes, and he has read on his own since.

What happened in those three quiet weeks was not a failure of formation; it was formation. He learned that his father's love for Scripture did not depend on his

That trust costs the parent something. It costs control, it costs the assurance that the child is performing correctly, and it requires the parent to trust God with the child's interior life rather than managing that interior life through enforcement — and that costly trust is itself formation. The child who watches a parent trust God with his disobedience learns something the child who watches a parent panic over it never learns: he learns that God is patient, that grace is real, that the relationship survives failure.

THE THEOLOGY OF GOD YOUR CHILD WILL CARRY

Here is the thing that grieves me most as a pastor. The moralist model produces adults who cannot receive grace, because they were raised in a system where performance was the currency and grace was the reward for good behavior — so that when they fail as adults, and they will, they do not know how to bring failure to God. They hide it. They perform harder. They white-knuckle their way through guilt, because the only model they were given for failure is to work harder, produce more, and earn their way back into favor. That is not the Christian life. It is its exhausting counterfeit, and it produces burnout, hidden

I have counseled adults in their forties who cannot pray after a moral failure because they believe, at the gut level, that God is disappointed in them the way their parents were disappointed in them at age nine — the disappointment was the catechism, the gospel was the footnote, and the footnote did not survive adulthood. I have heard versions of this from people who grew up in moralist homes, where the child's spiritual life became fused with the parent's emotional state, so that God was happy when Mom was happy and disappointed when Dad was worried. The parent became the functional mediator, and Christ, the actual mediator, was crowded out.

The way you respond to your child's failure today is forming how your child will respond to his own failure at thirty-five. If the response today is wrath, withdrawal, or conditional love, then the thirty-five-year-old will expect wrath, withdrawal, and conditional love from God; but if the response today is truth spoken in love, consequences paired with grace, and repair that restores the relationship, then the thirty-five-year-old will know in his bones that God meets sinners the same way. He will know the Father does not withdraw when he sins. He will know the cross already settled the question of whether he is loved. He will know that repentance is the door back into the warm place, not the price of admission.

You are not raising children. You are raising adults — and the adults you are raising will carry the theology of your home into their own homes, their own marriages, their own failures, their own encounters with God, and what they carry will either free them or bind them. The gospel frees. The moralist counterfeit binds. So preach the

CHAPTER SIX

Discipline, Correction, and the Shape of Grace

Grace-based discipline that forms a child's view of God — how to correct without anger, and what your discipline teaches about sin and grace.

Every parent disciplines, and the question is never whether you will correct your children but what your correction is forming in them — because correction, like everything else in the household, is catechesis. The way you handle a child's failure teaches that child something about who God is, what sin does, how grace operates, and whether restoration is real; get those four wrong, and you will produce a child with a distorted image of God that no sermon will easily undo.

Most Christian households discipline reactively. The child does something wrong, and the parent responds out of whatever he happens to be feeling in that moment —

TWO WAYS DISCIPLINE WOUNDS A CHILD

The first is wrath-based correction. The child sins, the parent erupts — loud, sometimes physical, always out of proportion to the offense — the child is scared, the parent eventually calms down, and the incident is never revisited because no repair is ever made. What the child learns from that sequence, repeated over years, is a single sentence about God: when I sin, He erupts; He is angry, He is unpredictable, He calms down eventually, but the eruption is what I remember. This is a theology of fear, and the child obeys because he dreads the explosion rather than because he loves — a fear that tends to produce one of two children, the one rigid and terrified of any mistake, or the one who learns to hide everything, because hiding is safer than being seen.

I have met adults in their forties who still flinch internally when they pray, because the God they are praying to sounds like the father who screamed at them when they were nine. That father did not mean to teach it; he was angry, and he was also, in many cases, only repeating what had been done to him — which is how

I have been in this indictment. I have raised my voice at my sons in ways that were about my frustration rather than their formation, and I have confused my own emotional overflow with parental authority. More than once I have gone back to a child and said that the way I corrected him was wrong — not the correction, the way; that I was angry, that I brought my anger into the room, that he absorbed it, and that it was on me. And I have told him, plainly, that God does not correct him the way I corrected him in that moment, that God corrects him because He loves him, and that His correction does not come with the kind of anger that makes a child afraid to be near Him.

That repair is essential, and it is deeply uncomfortable, because a father who goes back to his son and admits that his anger, not the child's behavior, was the problem is a father losing the illusion of infallibility that many men cling to. But the illusion was never serving the child; it was serving the father's ego — and the ego is not the basis of parental authority. Christ is.

The second pattern is withdrawal-based correction. The child sins, the parent does not erupt but goes cold — withdrawing affection, becoming distant — and the child feels it and learns that when he sins, love is removed: that God pulls back when he fails, that the distance grows when he is bad and shrinks when he is good. This is subtler than

Withdrawal does not look as dramatic as wrath; it looks calm, it looks controlled. But the child raised by a parent who goes cold after a failure learns something devastating about love itself — that it has conditions, that closeness must be earned, that failure creates distance — and he carries it into every relationship he has, the one with God included. I have counseled married adults who cannot receive grace from their own spouse because a parent withdrew: they do not know how to stay close after a failure, they expect the distance, they were trained for it in a thousand small withdrawals across fifteen years of childhood, and undoing that training is sometimes the work of decades.

BIBLICAL DISCIPLINE: THE TRAINER, NOT THE JUDGE

Hebrews 12 is the text most Christian parents know on this subject.

| *The Lord disciplines those He loves.*

— HEBREWS 12:6

That is true, but the verse sits inside a passage about endurance, about running the race, about the great cloud of witnesses — and the discipline of the Lord there is not punitive but formative, the discipline of a trainer rather than a judge. The Greek word is *paideia*: training, instruction, the formation of a child, the same word the

This distinction decides everything. Punitive discipline asks how do I stop this behavior; formative discipline asks how do I use this moment to shape who this child is becoming — the first about control and the second about growth, the first producing either compliance or rebellion while the second produces a child who is learning, over years, to see his own sin honestly, to receive grace, and to grow through it.

Here is what that looks like in a home. The child fails, and the parent responds not from anger but from purpose — clear about what happened, naming it without minimizing or euphemism: you lied, you hit your brother, you disobeyed what we agreed on. The child needs the truth about what he did, because truth is what God gives, and it is a gift even when it hurts; and so the parent names why it matters — not because I said so, but because lying breaks trust, because violence wounds a person made in God's image, because obedience in this house is not about my power but about the kind of person God is forming you into. The why ties the behavior to something larger than the parent's preference: the character of God and the dignity of other people.

Then comes the consequence, because consequences are real in a gospel household — grace does not mean no consequences, it means consequences inside the context of unbreakable love. The child loses a privilege, makes restitution, apologizes to the person he hurt, and the consequence is proportionate, clear, and tied to the

*The repair is what teaches the child the
gospel. Sin is real, consequences are
real, grace is real, restoration is real.
All four. Not three. Not two. All four, in
order.*

A household that practices all four is teaching its children the shape of grace, and the shape of grace is not that sin does not matter but that sin matters enormously, that God has dealt with it in Christ, and that because He has dealt with it you are not defined by it and can grow through it rather than be destroyed by it. That is the most important thing a child can learn about the moral life — and he will learn it not from a theology class but from the way his parents handle his Tuesday evening failure.

**WHEN YOUR ANGER IS REALLY ABOUT
YOU**

This does not mean you should never feel anger; when a child endangers himself or another person, anger is a reasonable response, and appropriate anger is focused, brief, and proportionate to the situation. But what most parents feel in the daily corrections of childhood is not that — it is accumulated frustration discharged at the nearest available target, and the child knows the difference.

Here is a practice I learned late and wish I had learned early. When one of my sons does something that triggers my anger, I pause — not because I am serene, but because I know from experience that the words I say in the first ten seconds of anger are the words my son will remember for years, and if I want those words to form him rather than wound him, I have to choose them instead of react with them. The pause is not natural; it is learned, and it is one of the most important disciplines a parent can develop, because it is the discipline of bringing your own flesh under the authority of the Spirit before you try to bring your child under the authority of the household.

Let me also address the spanking question, since it

The costly hope in this chapter is that you can change: if you have been a wrathful parent, you can repent; if you have been a withdrawing parent, you can learn to stay close; if your discipline has been reactive, you can make it purposeful — and the repair for what you have already done begins with honesty. Go to your child, name what you did, apologize for the spirit behind it, tell him what God's correction actually looks like, and then begin, today, to correct differently. Children are remarkably forgiving when the repentance is real, because they have been waiting for you to see what they have been seeing for years; and when you see it and name it, the relationship does not weaken but strengthens — for the child learns that even the parent is under God's formation, and that gives him permission to be under it too.

ONE HOUSE, ONE VOICE ON DISCIPLINE

This happens in almost every two-parent home. One parent is stricter, the other more lenient; one responds with heat, the other with calm; one follows through on consequences, the other forgets or relents — and the child, who is watching everything, learns that the moral structure of the household is not stable but shifts depending on who is in the room. That instability does not form a child. It produces a child who is learning to manage adults rather than learning to manage himself.

The correction is not that both parents become identical, because temperamental differences are real and they are not going away; the correction is alignment. The two need a conversation, away from the children, about what the household's discipline is actually for — what are we trying to form, what are the non-negotiable behaviors, what are the proportionate consequences, and when one of us is in the moment with a child, what does the other one do. That conversation, had in advance, prevents the breakdown that happens when two parents try to improvise a response in real time while the child watches.

I will tell you where Susanna and I failed and what we learned. Early on we had no alignment: I was the stricter parent and she was more lenient, and the boys learned fast that if Dad said no, there was a chance Mom would say yes if they caught her at the right moment. We were being

After a particularly chaotic day we sat down one evening and made a rule that changed everything: if one parent has made a decision about discipline, the other backs it in front of the child — always, even when the other disagrees — and the disagreement happens later, in private, between the two of us. This did not mean we always agreed; it meant the child always saw agreement, and that consistency gave the household a stability it had lacked. After the children were in bed we would debrief — I think you were too harsh on that one, I think you let that one go too easily — and we would talk it through and adjust, so that the next time we were closer to aligned. Over years this produced something neither of us could have produced alone: a discipline culture that was firm, consistent, and gracious, not because either of us was naturally all three, but because together, through conversation and compromise, we became all three.

CORRECT IN PRIVATE, FORM THE CHILD

I also want to address public correction versus private correction, because it matters more than most parents realize. A child corrected in front of his siblings, his friends, or other adults receives not only the correction but the shame of being corrected publicly — and shame is not conviction. Conviction says you did something wrong and here is how to make it right; shame says you are wrong and everyone can see it.

One more thing I learned late and wish I had learned early. The most effective discipline I have ever administered was not the strictest; it was the most connected. The correction that changed my son's behavior most was not the one with the biggest consequence but the one where he felt most known — where I named what he did, connected it to who he was becoming, applied a consequence that made sense, and then held him, so that the whole sequence, from naming to repair, took place inside a relationship he knew was unbreakable.

Children will accept correction from someone they trust, and they will resist correction from someone they fear, and the difference between trust and fear is not the severity of the consequence but the quality of the relationship. A parent who has invested in the relationship — who has been present, who has listened, who has played and laughed and been available — has earned the right to

Your discipline is forming something — either a child who understands grace or a child who fears God, and not the holy fear of Scripture, which is awe in the presence of holiness, but the other kind: the fear that flinches, the fear that hides, the fear that will not come near. That fear is not the fruit of Christian parenting. It is the fruit of parenting that forgot the gospel at the moment it mattered most.

So correct your children, and do it clearly, honestly, proportionately, and with repair — do it so that when your child thinks about what God is like, the first thing he remembers is not your anger but your steadiness, your honesty, your willingness to call the thing what it is and to love him through it anyway. That is the shape of grace, and that is what the home is supposed to teach. Now we need to talk about the thing that is catechizing your child more hours a day than you are. We need to talk about their phone.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Screens, Algorithms, and the Catechesis of Attention

*Kids, screens, and faith — how the smartphone
disciples a child's attention, and what Christian
parents can do about screen time that still works.*

You cannot write a book about forming faith in children in 2026 and pretend the old questions are the only ones, because for many hours of most days your child's primary catechist is not you — it is an algorithm trained to hold their attention by any means available, and whatever it is forming in them competes directly with whatever you are trying to form. You should know what you are up against.

A smartphone is not a television, not a radio, not a video game; those are older technologies, and a generation of Christian parents has tried to govern the new one with the old rules — limit screen time, use parental controls, put the computer in a central room — rules that worked,

If that sounds like overstatement, read the public testimony of the engineers who built these systems, many of whom have admitted that they do not let their own children use the platforms they made — and they know what those platforms do, because they built them to do exactly that. These are not neutral tools your child uses for homework and occasionally for fun; they are formation environments with a theology of the human person, and their theology is that the person is a consumer of stimulus whose attention is a resource to be extracted.

That theology stands in direct opposition to the Christian one, which says the person is a soul made for communion with God, whose attention is a gift to be given back to the Creator in worship and to the neighbor in love. The phone's theology says your attention is yours only in the legal sense, that it exists to be harvested — and both cannot shape your child at the same rate, so one will win. If your child receives forty-five minutes of the Christian theology on Sunday morning and six hours a day of the other one, the math is not complicated.

WHAT THE SMARTPHONE IS ACTUALLY DOING TO YOUR CHILD

Most parents think the danger is content; they worry about

Jonathan Haidt has documented this at length: the adolescent mind is being reshaped by a platform-based childhood in ways that produce unprecedented anxiety, depression, and attention fragmentation, and these are not incidental side effects but the natural result of training a developing brain on intermittent variable reinforcement — the same mechanism that makes slot machines addictive. The platform delivers a reward, withholds a reward, delivers a larger one, then withholds again until the brain learns to chase, and the chasing itself becomes the settled state of mind. The child is not choosing to be distracted; the child's brain has been trained to be distracted, and now the distraction is the default.

This carries spiritual consequences most Christian parents have not considered, because prayer requires sustained attention, and so does Scripture, and so does listening to a sermon, sitting in silence with God, confessing, repenting — every practice of the Christian life depends on a capacity the smartphone is systematically dismantling in your child. You are trying to form a child in a faith that requires slow, focused, interior attention while the device in their pocket trains their brain in the exact opposite direction, and the device is winning. Not because it is smarter than you. Because it has more hours.

I am not saying no phones, and I am not saying throw out the internet; I am a pastor who communicates daily through these tools, my sons have earned graduated levels of device access over time, and I am no Luddite. What I am saying is narrower and harder to escape: if you do not have

WHY ATTENTION IS A SPIRITUAL MATTER

The historic Christian tradition has understood this for centuries, treating the capacity to attend to God, to the neighbor, to the word of Scripture, and to one's own soul as the very substrate of the Christian life. The saints trained that capacity, treating attention as a muscle that strengthens through use and atrophies through neglect, because they knew a scattered mind cannot easily pray, cannot easily love, cannot easily meet God in Scripture. They did not have our devices, but they knew what a disordered soul does when it has no disciplines of attention: it becomes shallow, it becomes frantic, it becomes incapable of the long, slow, quiet attention God requires.

Simone Weil wrote that prayer is attention, and she meant it technically — the capacity to hold one's mind before God, without distraction, without chasing the next stimulus, is the very thing prayer is. A child raised on a device that delivers a new stimulus every few seconds is being trained, all day, in the opposite direction, formed in a rhythm that runs short, shorter, shortest, stimulus after stimulus after stimulus, with no silence, no boredom, no waiting. That is catechesis. The child who cannot tolerate five minutes of silence cannot be still before God; the child who cannot tolerate a slow story cannot read a Gospel; the child whose reward circuits have been trained by infinite scroll cannot easily accept that faith is a long obedience.

And the device is not only training attention; it is training desire, because the algorithm learns what your child wants and gives them more of it, until over time the child's wanting is shaped by what the algorithm has taught them to want. The child does not want God, because the child has been trained to want stimulus; the child does not want Scripture, because the child has been trained to want content that confirms what they already believe; the child does not want the hard, slow work of growth, because the child has been trained to want immediate satisfaction. You may have worried the platform corrupted your child's morals; more quietly, it has corrupted your child's desires — and desire is the engine of the spiritual life. A child who desires God will grow toward God through difficulty. A child whose desires have been trained elsewhere will not, no matter how many programs you run them through.

You stand between your child and a system built to harvest them. Stand there. It is one of the most pastoral things a parent can do.

CHRISTIAN SCREEN-TIME RULES THAT WORK, AND WHAT THEY COST

Delay, and delay hard, because the research on adolescent phone use is not ambiguous, and delaying a personal smartphone into the teenage years is one of the most load-bearing decisions you will make. A dumb phone or a watch for safety is fine; a smartphone with social media and infinite access is not, so hold it back until your child is old enough to have some chance of using it with formed resistance — which is not twelve, not thirteen, and in most cases older than you would like. You will be in a minority, but you are already in a minority by pursuing serious Christian formation, and this is one of the places the minority is right.

Keep devices out of bedrooms — every device, including yours — because the bedroom is a sanctuary, and nothing that wants a piece of your child's attention at two in the morning gets into that room. This rule is among the hardest to keep, and it is the parents who break it: if you want your children to leave their phones downstairs at nine, you will leave yours there too, since your phone is catechizing you at the same hours it is catechizing them. The rule applies all the way up.

Replace before you remove, because taking screens away without offering something that meets the human need the screen was meeting is a setup for failure; a bored

Model it, because you will not win any of this if your own attention is captured. Your children watch you reach for the phone at the first break in conversation, watch you disappear into it at dinner, watch you fill every quiet moment with input, and they are being catechized by your relationship with your device as much as by their own. So put phones in a basket during dinner, keep yours out of the bedroom, take one day a week of severely limited use, and sit with your own Bible, in paper, at a table, where the children can see you doing it. You cannot hand them a relationship with God while modeling a relationship with your phone that is more intimate than your relationship with God. They will read the real one.

And talk about it openly, because your children are not blind and often know more than you do about what the platforms are doing to them. Come to them in humility — I want us, as a family, to think carefully about how these devices are forming us, and I want your help figuring out what is wise — and you will get a more honest conversation than you expect, because children resent rules imposed

The costly hope is that attention can be retrained; it is slow and it is difficult, but a child whose attention has been fed for years on the platforms can, with time and discipline and help, recover the capacity for slower, deeper attention. I have seen it happen. It requires the parent to be in the process with the child, it requires the household to change, and it cannot be done to the child — it has to be done with them.

THE PHONE AS A RIVAL WORSHIP DEVICE

There is one more dimension to this, because it touches worship in a way most parents have not considered. Worship is not a Sunday activity; it is the orientation of a person's deepest attention toward whatever they regard as most worthy — and by that measure the phone is a worship device, training attention, directing desire, forming what the user regards as most worthy of their time, their emotion, their energy. When a child spends four hours a day on a device, they are being formed in worship. The only question is what they are worshipping.

The algorithm does not care about your child's soul; it cares about engagement, measuring what your child watches longest, clicks most, and responds to most strongly, then feeding them more of it, until over time it learns your child better than your child knows themselves — their fears, their insecurities, their triggers — and exploits all of them. Not because the algorithm is evil in a

When Paul wrote that we should take every thought captive to Christ, he was describing what happens when a person's attention is rightly oriented; the phone does the opposite, taking every thought captive to the feed, and a child whose thoughts are captive to the feed is a child whose worship is being redirected without their knowledge or consent. If they are scrolling social media, they are worshiping the opinion of their peers; if they are watching content about their bodies, they are worshiping appearance; if they are consuming outrage, they are worshiping the feeling of being right; if they are gaming for hours, they are worshiping achievement in a world that rewards faster than the real one. None of these are neutral. All of them are forming what your child considers worthy of their deepest attention, and whatever has your child's deepest attention has your child's worship.

The Christian answer is not to ban all technology, which is neither possible nor wise; the answer is to teach your child to think about attention the way a disciple thinks about worship — where is your attention going, what is it forming in you, is the thing that has your attention worthy of it, is it making you more like Christ or less. Those questions, asked regularly, in a household where the parents are asking them about their own attention, produce a child who can use technology without being used by it. That distinction, between use and mastery, is the one Paul makes:



All things are lawful for me, but I will not be

— 1 CORINTHIANS 6:12

When I see my sons on their phones for a long stretch, I have started asking a different question — not how long have you been on that, but what is that doing to you. The first question is about time; the second is about formation, and it invites the child to consider what is happening inside them rather than what they owe me in compliance. They do not always like it, but they have started asking it of themselves, and a child who can ask what is this doing to me is a child learning to steward their own attention — one of the most important skills a young person can develop in this generation, because the forces competing for that attention are fierce and growing, and the only defense against a captured attention is a trained one.

TO THE PARENT WHO ALREADY GAVE THE PHONE

I want to close with a word to the parent who has already given the phone over and is now trying to get it back, because undoing a decision is harder than making one, and the parents living inside the regret of premature screen access need more than guilt.

You are not the only one — you are not even in the minority. Most parents I counsel gave their children a device earlier than they now wish, and they did it because the child was the last in the friend group without one, because the school required it, because the child was bored and the parent was tired and the screen was the easiest answer, because they did not know what the device would do to a child's attention, sleep, social development,

Let me offer something other than guilt: you made a decision with incomplete information. The research on adolescent mental health and smartphone use has moved fast in the last several years, so that what we know now we did not know five years ago, and what little we did know was not being communicated clearly by the people selling the devices. You are not a bad parent for that decision; you are a parent who now has better information and needs a strategy for acting on it. Do not give up. The battle for your child's attention is the battle for your child's soul, and you fight it with patience, with honesty, with your own example, and with the confidence that the God who formed your child's mind is greater than the algorithm trying to capture it.

There is no Christian formation without trained attention, and no trained attention without protection from the forces actively training it the other way — and that protection is the parent's job, because nobody else will do it. The schools will not. The church cannot. The broader culture is the one doing the harm. And when you fall short of this, which you will, go back to the principle we learned two chapters ago: repair. Admit what you are doing, tell your children you are trying to get better at it too, let them see you struggle with it the way they struggle with it, and do not pretend you have it under control if you do not. The honesty will go further than the rules.

The next chapter is about the thing your child watched before they ever watched your phone, the thing they have been watching since the day they were born — your marriage, and what it is teaching them about God, love,

CHAPTER EIGHT

Marriage as the First Classroom

*How your marriage shapes your child's faith —
why the relationship your children watch teaches
them what covenant, love, and God are.*

Before your child watched you pray, they watched you love your spouse; before they heard you read Scripture, they heard you argue; and before they ever saw you worship on a Sunday morning, they saw you at the breakfast table, where they learned whether the person across from you was met with tenderness or with indifference. Your marriage is the first classroom your child ever attended, and they enrolled the day they were born.

Most Christian parents keep marriage and parenting in separate rooms, as though the relationship between two adults and the work of raising children were different enterprises that touch only at the practical seams — scheduling, discipline, money — while the marriage itself goes on undisturbed in its own quarters. It does not work that way. The marriage is rarely understood as a place

A child watching a marriage is learning theology — a theology of love built from the questions the marriage answers without ever stating them. Is love patient, or does it erupt the moment it is inconvenienced; is it sacrificial, or does it keep a running scoreboard of who has given more; is it honest, or does it perform in public and deteriorate in private; is it durable, or does it fracture under pressure and never get repaired? The child is not thinking in these categories. The child is absorbing them, and they are being written into the child's deepest assumptions about what human relationships are, what God's relationship with His people might look like, and whether the kind of love the Bible describes actually exists or is only aspirational fiction.

I have watched this play out for two decades, and the pattern has been almost embarrassingly consistent: the families whose children's faith proved most durable were not the ones with the heaviest investment in children's ministry, but the ones where the marriage was alive — where the parents were kind to each other in the kitchen, where the father looked at the mother with something in his eyes that the children could see, where conflict happened but repair happened too, and the children watched both. Those children grew up believing covenant is real, because they had seen it; they grew up with an intuitive trust in the faithfulness of God, because the first covenant they ever observed, the marriage of their parents, was a covenant that held.

Your marriage is not a background condition to the work of forming your children; it is the foreground. It is the primary text the child is reading, and every other text — the Bible, the sermon, the devotional — is read against it, confirmed by it when the marriage says love is real and undermined by it when the marriage says love is only a performance. You cannot teach your child about the love of God while living inside a marriage that contradicts it. The child will believe the marriage.

THE INVISIBLE LESSONS YOUR MARRIAGE TEACHES

There are specific things a child learns from watching a marriage — the lessons no curriculum teaches and no program can replace.

The child learns about conflict, because every marriage has it, and the only real question is what the conflict teaches. Where it is avoided, the child learns that disagreement is dangerous, that peace means the absence of honest conversation, that love cannot survive a hard

I owe the argument something about my own marriage. Susanna and I have had seasons where it was not teaching our sons what we wanted it to teach. There was a year, not long ago, when ministry demands and sheer exhaustion had pushed us into a functional partnership rather than an intimate marriage; we were efficient, and we were not close. And one of our boys, the one with the eyes that miss nothing, said to Susanna one evening, you and Dad do not laugh together anymore. He was not criticizing. He was observing — and his observation was devastating in its accuracy, because we had in fact stopped laughing, stopped looking at each other with the thing the children needed to see, and become coworkers in a household that was running while the marriage inside it was not alive. The children knew it.

That observation turned us. We decided, together, to invest in the marriage as a spiritual act on behalf of our children — not because they needed to see a perfect marriage, but because they needed to see one that was being tended, where the adults were choosing each other

The child learns about affection. Physical affection between a husband and a wife, in front of the children, teaches the child that love is not an abstraction — that it has a body, that it is given and received. I kiss Susanna in the kitchen; I hold her hand at the table; I hug her when she walks in the door. I am not performing. I am doing what married people who love each other do, and my sons are watching, learning what a man who loves a woman looks like — that tenderness is not weakness, that affection is not embarrassing, that a marriage with physical warmth is a marriage that is alive. Some of you have stopped touching your spouse in front of your children, whether because the marriage has grown cold or because the gesture now feels uncomfortable, and your children have noticed; they learn from the absence of affection as surely as they would learn from its presence.

The child learns about respect, because how a husband speaks to his wife, and how a wife speaks to her husband, is one of the most formative things in any household. A husband who dismisses his wife, who corrects her in front of the children, who treats her opinions as less weighty than his own, is teaching his sons how to treat women and teaching his daughters what to accept from men; a wife who belittles her husband, who rolls her eyes at his ideas, is teaching the same lessons in reverse. Children catalog every interaction, building their reference for what

The child learns about forgiveness, and this may be the most important lesson of all. Your child needs to see you forgive your spouse — not in general but specifically, in the aftermath of a conflict they witnessed — needs to hear you say, I was wrong, I am sorry, will you forgive me, and then needs to hear the other person say, yes. That exchange, repeated over years, teaches the child more about the gospel than any sermon can; for the gospel is the story of a God who forgives, and the child who has watched forgiveness in action, in the most important relationship in the house, carries a frame for receiving and giving it that the child who has never seen it simply does not have.

COVENANT THE CHILD CAN SEE

Some of you are reading this in marriages that are not well. The marriage is strained. The affection is gone. The conflict is constant, or the silence is total. And you are reading with a growing weight, because you know what your marriage is teaching your children and you do not know how to change it.

Hear me: I am not writing this to add guilt, but to name the thing honestly, because naming it is the first step toward changing it. If your marriage is not teaching your children what you want it to teach, the answer is not to perform a better marriage in front of them — they will see through the performance — but to actually tend the marriage: to get help, to go to a counselor, to talk to your pastor, to begin the repair that has been deferred for years. That is not a distraction from raising your children. It is

Consider what the marriage teaches about covenant. We live in a culture that treats commitment as provisional — you commit until you no longer want to, you stay until staying costs more than leaving — and children absorb that message from every direction. The marriage in the home is the counter-message. It is the place where the child sees two people who made a promise and are keeping it: not because keeping it is easy, not because every day is good, but because the promise is real and the vows are load-bearing.

When your child sees you choose your spouse on a hard day, choose to be kind when you are tired, choose to stay when staying is difficult, you are teaching them that covenant is not a contract. A contract has exit clauses; a covenant has steadfastness. And the God of the Bible is a covenant God who does not exit and does not abandon — so your marriage, kept in faithfulness over decades, becomes the child's first evidence that this is true.

*You cannot reform the classroom
while the curriculum stays broken.*

It is not too late to change what your marriage is teaching, even if the children are older, even if the damage has already been done. A marriage that begins to heal in front of the children, that begins to warm after a cold

So tend your marriage. Not for the marriage alone, but for the children who are watching it, learning from it, and building their theology of love from what they see in it every single day.

GUARD WHAT IS ALIVE

If you are in a marriage that is alive, guard it. The forces working against a Christian marriage are relentless. Exhaustion, distraction, unresolved conflict, the slow drift of two people who stop choosing each other because the logistics of life have replaced the intimacy.

Make time for each other that is not about the children; talk about something other than the schedule; pray together even when you do not feel like it; confess to each other, forgive each other, touch each other, laugh together. Your children need you to do these things — not because they are watching a performance, but because they are absorbing a reality, and a marriage that is being tended teaches them what God's faithfulness looks like.

If you are in a marriage that is not alive, do not resign yourself to it. Talk to each other first — not about the children, not about the schedule, but about what has gone cold between you and why. Many marriages die not from a single catastrophe but from a thousand small neglects: the conversation skipped because you were tired, the touch

I have counseled couples who could not remember the last time they had a conversation that was not about logistics, and when I asked what they used to talk about when they were dating, they both got quiet — and then they remembered: their dreams, their fears, their faith, what they wanted their life to look like, what they believed about God. Those conversations had been replaced, gradually, by exchanges about who was picking up the children and whether the mortgage payment had cleared — not deliberately, but erosionally. Life eroded the intimacy, and nobody noticed until the river had cut through to bare rock.

The repair begins with a decision, not a feeling. A decision: we are going to talk to each other again about things that matter, we are going to pray together again, we are going to touch each other with tenderness even when it does not come naturally — because discipline precedes desire, and the tenderness will follow the decision if we sustain it. That decision is not romantic. It is covenantal. And covenantal decisions are the ones that save marriages.

THE PASTOR'S MARRIAGE

I want to speak to the dynamic I have seen in ministry marriages, because I live inside it. The pastor's marriage carries a weight other marriages do not. Not because the pastor is more important. Because the pastor's marriage is more visible, more scrutinized, more subject to the

Susanna has told me, more than once, that she sometimes feels like she gets whatever is left over after the church has taken what it needs — and she is not wrong. There have been seasons where I gave the best of my energy to the congregation and came home with the scraps, where I was patient with church members and impatient with her, where I listened carefully to a counseling appointment and then dismissed her concerns at the dinner table. That is not pastoral faithfulness. That is pastoral idolatry — making the church the center rather than the God of the church, sacrificing the marriage on the altar of ministry productivity.

If you are in ministry, hear me: your marriage is not an obstacle to your ministry, it is your first ministry. If you are preaching about the love of God on Sunday and your spouse does not feel loved by you on Tuesday, something is broken, and it is not the sermon schedule. It is you. Fix the Tuesday before you preach the Sunday.

I have had to learn this the hard way, more than once, and each time the lesson has been the same: the congregation can survive a week without my best, but Susanna should not have to, and the children should not have to. The household is the first call on my energy, and when I get that order wrong, everything else suffers — including the very ministry I was prioritizing over the household.

A word about physical intimacy, because it matters to

When physical intimacy dies in a marriage, it takes the emotional warmth with it: the parents become roommates, and the children feel the chill. I am not reducing marriage to the bedroom; I am saying that the bedroom affects the kitchen, and the kitchen is where the children eat, and the meals they eat in a warm kitchen form them differently than the meals they eat in a cold one. So guard the whole marriage — not only the parts the children see, but the whole thing — because the children are formed by the whole thing, whether they can name what they sense or not.

Seek help. Talk to your pastor; find a counselor; read the books that have helped others — not because a dead marriage is a personal failure, though it may involve confession, but because the children in your house are building their theology of love from what they see, and what they see right now is not what you want them to carry. The repair of a marriage, done in front of children over months and years, teaches them that dead things can be raised. That is a resurrection theology. It is the most

WHEN THE MARRIAGE HAS ENDED

And if your marriage has ended, through death or divorce, hear this. The formation of your children is not over. The household looks different now. The catechism has changed. But the four channels are still running. What you praise, what you worry about, what you repeat, what you rest in. Those channels are still forming your children. And the way you handle the grief, the transition, the rebuilding, is itself formation.

A parent who grieves honestly, who refuses to become bitter, who keeps loving the children through the upheaval, is teaching a theology of resilience that the child in the intact marriage may never learn. Your household is not disqualified. It is different. And God is in different the same way He is in whole.

Let me speak directly to the parent walking through divorce, because the formation challenges are particular, and your children are watching all of them: whether you speak of their other parent with bitterness or with restraint, whether you use them as messengers or as weapons or as people, whether the faith you profess survives the worst thing that has happened to your family.

I have counseled parents who handled divorce in ways that devastated their children's faith — not through the divorce itself, but through the behavior during and after it. The parent who badmouthed the other parent in front of the children; the parent who used the children as a bargaining chip; the parent so consumed by their own pain that the children's pain became invisible. In each case the child's theology of love, covenant, and faithfulness

I have also counseled parents who handled it in ways that preserved and even deepened their children's faith — the parent who said, your father and I could not make our marriage work, and that is a grief I carry, but he is still your father and I will not speak against him in this house; the parent who said, I am angry and I am hurt, and I am bringing those things to God because they are too big to carry alone; the parent who prioritized the children's stability over their own need to process publicly. Those parents taught their children something about grace under pressure that no sermon could have taught, and they taught it by living it — at the hardest moment of their lives, in front of the people who needed to see it most.

If you are in that situation, hear me: your conduct during and after the divorce is one of the most significant formation moments in your children's lives. You did not choose the situation, but you can choose the conduct, and it will shape your children's understanding of what it means to follow Jesus when everything falls apart. So choose well — not perfectly, but well — with as much grace and restraint and honesty as you can gather, and with the confidence that God is forming your children through this, even through this, if you will let Him.



Husbands, love your wives, as Christ loved the church and gave himself up for her.

— EPHESIANS 5:25

The next chapter is for the parents of teenagers, because the teenage years are the season when everything we have discussed goes underground, and the parent must

CHAPTER NINE

The Teenage Years, When Formation Goes Underground

When a teenager pulls away and questions the faith — what the adolescent brain is doing, when it is more than a phase, and how to keep the door open.

There is a day that comes for every parent, and you will not see it coming: the child who told you everything stops telling you things, the child who crawled into your lap during family worship now sits across the room and says nothing, the child who asked you about God at bedtime now reaches for the earbuds the moment the car door shuts. The door that was open is closing, and you did not hear it happen. You only noticed the silence.

Name it for what it is. The teenage years are the season when formation goes underground — and everything you built in the first twelve or thirteen years does not vanish so

This is normal, and it is also agonizing, because from where the parent stands it feels like loss, like drift, like the work has stopped or, worse, come undone — so the parent panics, and the panic runs in one of two directions. Either the parent grips harder, with more control, more surveillance, more pressure to perform the old closeness; or the parent withdraws, reading the distance as rejection and answering distance with distance.

Both responses wound the thing they mean to protect. Grip harder and you produce an adolescent who either submits in resentment or rebels in desperation; withdraw and you produce an adolescent who reads your retreat as proof that his pulling away was wrong, that your love was conditional on his accessibility all along. Neither road ends at a young adult with a mature faith. Both end at a young adult who learned, in the most critical years of his identity, that his parent could not handle who he was becoming.

**WHY THE TEST OF FAITH HAPPENS
WHERE YOU CANNOT SEE**

For the first twelve years, the child's faith was held inside yours; he believed because you believed, prayed because you prayed, went to church because you took him, so that his faith was, in a real sense, your faith, borrowed. During adolescence he has to decide whether to keep it — whether the faith he inherited is the faith he will carry — and that decision cannot be made under supervision; it can only be made in the privacy of his own mind and heart. Your job, in this phase, is not to control the decision but to be present enough that he knows there is a safe place to land, whatever the decision turns out to be.

I have five sons. Some have already been through this; others are in it now. From the inside of it I can tell you that nothing in my pastoral training prepared me for watching my own child work out his faith in a way I could not direct — I could preach about it, I could counsel other parents through it, but when it was my son closing the bedroom door, my son answering in monosyllables, my son showing no flicker of interest in the things that used to light him up, I felt the same fear every parent feels, and I had to do the very thing I had counseled others to do, which was keep my hands open instead of clenched.

WHAT THE ADOLESCENT BRAIN IS

The neuroscience matters here, so let me name it plainly: the teenage brain is undergoing a massive reorganization, and the prefrontal cortex — the seat of executive function, long-term planning, impulse control, the capacity to hold competing ideas in tension — is not fully developed until the mid-twenties. Through adolescence the brain is being pruned and rewired, with the emotional centers running at full power while the rational centers are still under construction, so that the adolescent feels everything at maximum intensity while carrying a diminished capacity to process those feelings with an adult's balance.

This is why teenagers are so confusing to their parents: the teenager feels with the intensity of an adult and processes with the capacity of a brain still being built. He is not choosing to be irrational — his brain is in a construction zone — and the faith he is weighing is being weighed by a brain that runs ideas through the emotional centers first, so that his experience of faith is heavily mediated by feeling. If God feels distant, God is distant; if prayer feels empty, prayer is meaningless; if church feels boring, church has nothing for him. The parent who tries to argue a teenager out of his feelings with logic is arguing against a brain not yet wired to receive the argument.

This does not mean you abandon logic; it means you lead with relationship, because the adolescent brain is wired for relationship above nearly everything else. Peer bonds become paramount, but the parental bond does not disappear — it goes underground like everything else. The teenager who will not talk to you at the dinner table is still tracking whether you are present, still tracking whether you notice his absence, whether you care enough to keep

WHAT I HAVE LEARNED, AT COST

Here is what fifteen years of ministry and five sons have taught me about parenting a teenager in the faith. None of it came cheap.

Reduce the number of hills you will die on. When children are small, the parent draws every boundary; when they are teenagers, you must decide which boundaries are essential and which are negotiable — because if you fight over everything, hair and music and friends and curfew and phone and chores and clothing and language and church attendance, you will lose the teenager entirely, since he will conclude that you care more about control than about him. Hold the line on safety, on moral integrity, on respect in the house, and bend on the rest. The teenager with some agency, some room to make choices you would not make, is a teenager learning to be a person, and that learning is messy. It is also the point.

Stay in the room. When he pushes you away, stay in the room — not physically, because he needs the physical space, but relationally: keep asking about his day when all you get is one word back, keep inviting him to things when he keeps saying no, keep telling him you love him when he rolls his eyes, keep making his favorite meal, keep being interested in what interests him even when his interests confuse or concern you. The parent who refuses to withdraw when the teenager withdraws is the parent the teenager comes back to when the phase shifts — and it will shift, it always does, and the parent who was still there

Answer the questions he is not asking out loud. Teenagers ask theological questions with their behavior long before they ask them with their words, so that the one who refuses church is asking whether this faith is real or merely forced, the one who dates someone you disapprove of is asking whether you will love him if he does not do what you want, and the one who plays with ideas that contradict the family's beliefs is asking whether this faith is strong enough to survive examination. These are not rebellions. They are questions wearing the clothing of rebellion — and once you see the question under the behavior, you can answer the question instead of reacting to the behavior, which changes everything.

*They are not rebellions. They are
questions wearing the clothing of
rebellion.*

Let him see your faith in its adult complexity. To a small child you give faith in simple terms — God loves you, Jesus died for you, the Bible is true — but to a teenager those terms are no longer enough; he needs to see that faith has an adult version, that it can hold doubt, that it has wrestled hard questions, that it has survived suffering, that it is not naive. If the only faith he has ever seen is the children's version, he will discard it, because he is no longer a child. So give him the adult version: tell him about the hard

And pray more than you lecture. In the teenage years your primary spiritual work for the child shifts from instruction to intercession, because you have said what you needed to say and planted what you could plant; now you pray, and you pray specifically. You pray by name. You pray for his friends, because his friends are shaping him right now more than you are; you pray for his mind, because his mind is meeting ideas that challenge everything you taught him; you pray for his heart, because his heart is being pulled in several directions and you cannot choose which one wins. You pray for the Holy Spirit to do what only the Holy Spirit can do — take the seeds you planted and bring them to life in a soul you can no longer reach directly.

IF YOU THINK YOU STARTED DISCIPLING TOO LATE

Many parents of teenagers are terrified they began too late — they did not do the work in the early years, never built the household catechism, outsourced to the church, and now the teenager is pulling away and there is little foundation to stand on. If that is you, let me be honest: it is harder, and starting at fourteen is harder than starting at four. But it is not impossible, because God is not bound by your timeline, and the parent who starts being real with a teenager now — honest about his own failures, asking instead of lecturing, present instead of controlling — can

The teenage years are not the years you lose your child; they are the years your child decides whether to keep what you gave him. Your role is not to force the decision but to be the kind of person he wants to come back to once the decision is made. That is enough. It will not feel like enough. It is.

A STORY FROM MY OWN HOUSE

One of my older sons went through a season, around fifteen, when he stopped wanting to go to church. He announced no departure from the faith and gave no speech; he simply started saying he was tired on Sunday mornings, started finding reasons to stay home. He was not hostile. He was distant. And I felt the fear rise in me, the same fear I had counseled dozens of other parents through.

My first instinct was to mandate it — he lives under my roof, he will go to church — but that instinct came from fear, not wisdom. So Susanna and I talked, and we prayed, and we chose a different way. We told him church mattered to our family and that we wanted him there; we also told him we would not force him, because forced worship is not worship, and that if he chose to stay home on a given Sunday, that was his call and we would love him the same either way. And we asked him to tell us honestly what was going on.

He told us. Church felt boring; the sermons did not connect to his life; he felt like he was going through the motions. He was not rejecting God. He was rejecting the experience as he was having it — and those are different

So we made changes. I started talking with him after the service about the sermon, not as a quiz but as a conversation; I asked what he disagreed with, asked what confused him, let him push back on things I had said from the pulpit. That was uncomfortable for me. It was essential for him. Over several months he came back — not because we forced him, but because we made the faith a conversation instead of a mandate — and he is engaged now in a way he was not before, and I believe the engagement runs deeper because it was chosen rather than coerced.

Not every story ends that way. Some teenagers pull away and stay away a long time; some never come back to church even if they come back to God. But the point of the story is not the outcome — it is the posture, because the parent who listens, who does not panic, who keeps the relationship above the compliance, gives the teenager the best chance of owning the faith for himself. Whether he takes that chance is not in your hands. The posture is.

WHEN A TEEN DOUBTING FAITH IS NOT JUST A PHASE

One word for the parent whose teenager is not merely questioning the faith but is in a genuinely dark place — using substances, in a destructive relationship, harming himself, speaking of hopelessness. That is not the situation I have been describing; that situation calls for intervention, not patience. If your teenager is in danger, get help: talk to a counselor, talk to your pastor, and do not

The parent who steps into a crisis, who says I love you too much to watch this happen, is not violating his teenager's autonomy — he is exercising parental love at its highest and most costly. Do not confuse the patience I described for ordinary adolescence with passivity in the face of real danger. They are not the same thing.

THE FRIENDS, THE OTHER ADULTS, AND THE END OF THE TUNNEL

During adolescence the peer group becomes the primary social world, and this is normal — and it is terrifying, because the peer group is shaping your child in ways you cannot control and often cannot see. The friends your teenager chooses are, in a real sense, choosing the catechism he absorbs in the most impressionable years of his life.

That does not mean you choose his friends for him — that level of control breeds rebellion, not formation — but it does mean you should know who they are: invite them over, feed them, talk to them, watch how your child acts around them, because a teenager who becomes a different person in the presence of certain friends is a teenager whose formation is being pulled somewhere you need to understand. I have made it our practice to make our home the gathering place, my sons' friends in our house rather than my sons in houses I do not know, and this is not surveillance but hospitality with a purpose: when the friends are here, I can hear the conversations and see whether they bring out the best in my son or something else, and my son, watching me be kind to his friends, does

Your teenager also needs adults in his life who are not you — adults he respects, who share your faith, whom he can talk to when he cannot talk to you — and this is not a failure of your parenting but a feature of adolescent development, because he is individuating from you, and part of that requires other models of adult faith: a youth pastor, a mentor, a coach, a family friend, an uncle, a grandparent. They do not replace you; they extend you, showing your teenager that the faith you hold is not peculiar to your household but is held by other adults too, in their own way, with their own stories. I have intentionally put my sons in relationship with men in our church I trust — men who will tell them the truth, pray with them, and not let them get away with what they should not get away with — and my sons have conversations with those men they do not have with me. I am not offended by that. I am grateful for it, because the more voices my sons hear the faith from, the harder it is to dismiss as one man's opinion.

And the teenage years will end. I say this to the parent in the middle of them who cannot see the end: the withdrawal will ease, the resistance will soften, and the door that is closed will open again — not on your timeline, on his, but it will open. The parent who was still standing

The teenage years are a tunnel. It is dark in the tunnel, and the parent cannot see where it goes — but there is light at the far end, and the parent who keeps walking, keeps praying, keeps loving, comes out of it with his child, both of them changed, both of them deeper, connected in a way the easy years of childhood could never have produced.

Trust the process — not the therapeutic slogan, the actual theological one: God is at work in your teenager, and the Holy Spirit is pursuing him with a persistence that exceeds your own. Your job is not to be the Holy Spirit. Your job is to stay close enough that when the Spirit does His work, your teenager has someone safe to tell about it.



Train up a child in the way he should go; even when he is old he will not depart from it.

— PROVERBS 22:6

The next chapter is for the fathers, because everything I have described in these last several chapters depends, in a particular way, on the presence and posture of the man in the house.

CHAPTER TEN

Fathers, Presence, and the Weight of Blessing

*The Christian father as the spiritual leader of the
home — why a father's presence and blessing
form a child's faith, and a word to men raised
without one.*

I grew up without a father, and I have said it once already in this book and will say it again before the end, because it is the place everything in me starts. I know what absence does to a boy, and I have watched it do its slow work in the lives of the men I have pastored for twenty years — which is how I came to know something the church seems to have forgotten: that the conversation about Christian fatherhood has grown so sentimental it no longer lands on the men who most need to hear it. So this chapter will be blunt. If you are a father, I am asking you to stand inside the indictment with me, because I am already in it.

This kind of absence has a signature, and you can trace it with a few questions. Ask a child in a Christian home who prays for them by name at night, and where the mother does it — God bless her — she is often doing it alone; ask who reads Scripture with them, and the answer is often the mother again; ask who walks them through the hard conversations of purpose and sin and sex and failure and calling, and it is often the mother, or no one; ask who blesses them when they leave the house, and often the honest answer is no one. The father is at work, or on his phone, or decompressing, or simply not thinking about it. He is not hostile to the faith. He is just not carrying the weight.

THE SPIRITUAL WEIGHT A FATHER CARRIES

The weight is the word, and the biblical picture of a father is a man who carries weight on behalf of his household — the weight of provision, yes, but also the weight of prayer, of blessing, of correction delivered in love, the weight of deciding which direction the household will face, the weight of being the first one to repent when he has been wrong, the weight of being home when his people need

I have a theory about why so many men carry only the lighter weight, and it goes deeper than laziness: most Christian men were not fathered well themselves. Their own fathers, if present at all, modeled a fatherhood that was economic at best and absent at worst — men who provided and protected but did not pray with their children, or bless them, or speak over them, because no one had done the intimate, exposed work of spiritual fatherhood for them and the culture told them that intimacy was the mother's domain. The current generation inherited the void. They know something is missing, but they do not know what it is, and lacking a model they default to the only version they know — present, employed, attending, and absent at exactly the level where formation actually happens.

The Bible's understanding of fatherhood is not cultural but covenantal, and the father represents something that cannot be outsourced: however imperfectly, he represents the Fatherhood of God to his children, the first picture they get of what a Father is like. That is an enormous thing to lay on a man, and it is meant to be — meant to drive him to his knees, meant to send him to the actual Father, daily, for the grace he needs to represent Him at all. A Christian father is not a man who has mastered the old patriarchal script; he is a man who has become small enough before God to be used as a window — the window through which his children get their first glimpse of the Father's face.

This is why the stakes are not abstract. If the father is

THE HOLLOW PLACE

A man in my congregation came to me about three years ago, in his late thirties, with two sons, eight and six. He had been raised in a Christian home by a father who was doctrinally precise and emotionally unavailable — a man who could explain substitutionary atonement and had never once told his son he loved him — and the man now sitting in my office was carrying a wound he had never named, a wound that was leaking into his own fathering. He was repeating the pattern. He knew it. He did not know how to stop.

I asked him when he had last blessed his sons by name, and he looked at me as though I were speaking a foreign language, so I explained: lay your hand on your son's head, tell him who he is, tell him who God is making him, speak a future over him, and use the Aaronic blessing if you do not have your own words yet. He said he had never done it, that his father had never done it — and then he started crying, because he understood in that moment that the hollow place inside him was the place where a father's blessing was supposed to be.

He went home that night and blessed his eight-year-old for the first time, and he told me later that the boy looked up at him with wide eyes and said, Dad, do that again. The

*A generation of men is walking
around with a hollow place where a
father's blessing was supposed to be. Do
not let your children become those
men.*

This is why a Christian father must take his own formation seriously, because you cannot offer your children a God you do not know, and you cannot represent a Father whose face you rarely see. Your children will absorb your actual relationship with God, not the one you wish you had: if that relationship is thin, their inheritance is a thin God, and if it is alive, their inheritance is a living one. This is the most important pastoral work any man ever does, and also the work he is usually least equipped for, because the church has rarely disciplined men to do it and the culture has handed him no categories beyond breadwinner and occasional disciplinarian.

THREE THINGS A FATHER CAN START THIS WEEK

Let me be practical, because there are three things a father can begin this week that change the spiritual climate of a

The first is to bless your children by name, out loud, regularly — not as a performance but as a pattern. Lay your hand on the child's head and speak words over them: you are my son, I love you, I am proud of the way God is building you. The oldest words for it are the best ones, and you can borrow them until your own arrive:



The Lord bless you and keep you; the Lord make his face to shine upon you and be gracious to you; the Lord lift up his countenance upon you and give you peace.

— NUMBERS 6:24-26

Some of you are reading that and finding it strange, even foreign, and I understand, because the first time I did it with one of my sons I was self-conscious — and I kept doing it anyway, until it became one of the most load-bearing practices in my home. My sons expect it now; they ask for it when I forget. There is something in a child designed to receive a father's blessing, and it starves without it — starving is not too strong a word. Bless them now, while they are small, and keep blessing them when they are grown.

The second is to pray with your children, out loud, often — not for them, with them. Let them hear you thank God for specific things by name, let them hear you ask for mercy when you were wrong, let them hear you intercede for people outside the family, including the people who are hard for you to love, and let them hear you carry your worries to God rather than to the television. Prayer practiced in front of children catechizes them in what God is for and how He is to be approached; you cannot

The third is to repent in front of your children, and this one is harder, which is why most men avoid it. They believe that authority in the home is held by never showing weakness — but that is a cultural script, not a Christian one, and a father who is never wrong in front of his children is teaching them that Christianity is a performance of rightness, which is the opposite of the gospel. A father who turns to his child and says, I was wrong, I was short with you, that came out of my own stuff, I have asked God's forgiveness and now I am asking yours — that father is teaching something profoundly Christian, and the authority does not shrink but grows. The child learns that authority in this house is not brittle. It is weighty. It is honest. It is rooted in God, not in the father's ability to pretend.

I have had to do this many times, more than I would like. I have snapped at my sons, I have been withdrawn when I should have been present, I have come home from ministry with nothing left and spent the nothing on the people I most love — and every time I have gone back, admitted it, asked forgiveness, and prayed with the child about it, the relationship has strengthened rather than weakened. Children do not need an unimpeachable father. They need an honest one — a father who is being sanctified in front of them, not one pretending he has already arrived.

SONS, DAUGHTERS, AND A FATHER'S FIRST WORD

A man is a servant of God who carries weight for the sake of others, a man who is not afraid to kneel before God and not afraid to apologize, strong enough to be gentle — he works hard, protects what God has put under his care, is patient with his wife and tender with his children, and tells the truth when it costs him. Let your sons see it; do not lecture them, let them see it. They become what they watch, not what they hear.

To fathers of daughters: your daughters are watching you to learn what a man is like, and to learn how they should expect to be treated by one, which means the way you love their mother is a template, the way you speak to her is a template, the way you listen, or do not, is a template. One day a man will come to win her, and whether she can tell a true one from a false one will have been shaped, in large part, by you. Give her so much evidence of what love looks like that she can spot the counterfeit at a hundred yards.

THE BUSY FATHER AND THE DISCIPLINE OF PRESENCE

I want to add something I have not often seen in books on fatherhood, because I know it from the inside: the ministry father gives his best hours, his best energy, his best emotional availability to the congregation, and then, having been present all day for other people's families, he

That is a lie, and it has destroyed more pastoral families than I can count — and I have been in this sin. There were seasons when I gave my church my best and gave my family my empty, and the result was predictable: my sons pulled away, not from God but from me, because they had learned that their father's attention was a scarce resource other people consumed before they could reach it. The correction has been painful and is ongoing. I have had to learn to leave the office, turn off the phone, tell a congregant that the evening belongs to my family, and resist the savior complex that says I must be available to everyone at all hours. The church will survive without me for an evening; my sons will not survive without a father who is present. If you are a pastor reading this, hear me: your family is your first ministry, not your second, not your backup — get that order wrong and you may build a great ministry and lose your children.

But the deeper problem is not unique to pastors; it belongs to every father who is here but not present — the one who comes home every evening, eats at the table, attends the events, and whose mind is somewhere else, his phone in his hand, his work following him home in his head where he cannot set it down. You are a body in a chair, and your children have learned to tell the difference between a father who is in the room and a father who is with them.

The discipline of presence is one of the hardest disciplines of fatherhood, because it asks you to set things down — not the phone only, but the worry, the planning, the rehearsal of tomorrow's problems — and to be in the room you are in, with the people who are in it, giving them the thing they most need from you, which is not your provision and not your protection but your attention. I practice this imperfectly, but I practice it: when I sit down for dinner the phone goes in another room, and when a son is talking to me I stop and turn my body toward him — not because I am naturally attentive, but because I have learned that the moments I am tempted to half-listen are the very moments he is most likely to say the thing I need to hear. Children do not schedule their vulnerability. They tell you in the car, while you are making sandwiches, at nine-thirty at night when you are ready for bed — and miss those unscheduled moments and you miss the conversation that mattered most.

TO THE MAN WHO GREW UP WITHOUT A FATHER

I have saved a word for last, and it is for the men like me — the men who did not have a father, or had one whose

When you had no model, you are building the plane while flying it: there is no template, no voice in your memory that says, this is what a good father sounds like, only a silence where that voice should be — and the silence breeds two opposite errors. Either you try too hard, becoming an overwhelming presence that smothers rather than forms, or you withdraw, afraid you will repeat patterns you cannot even name, because the patterns are absences rather than actions. And how do you keep yourself from repeating an absence?

I have lived in both errors. In the early years I compensated — at every game, every practice, every school event, present in body to a degree that exhausted me, because I was terrified of being absent the way my father was absent — and my presence, driven by fear instead of love, had an edge my sons could feel. Fear-driven presence is a form of control; it looks like devotion and feels like surveillance. Then I swung the other way and pulled back, telling myself I was giving them space when I was really protecting myself from an intensity of fatherhood I did not know how to regulate. Children always feel the difference between a father who gives them room and a father who is retreating.

The correction came, as it often does, through my wife. Susanna sat me down one evening and said the thing that changed the course of my fathering: you are either trying to be the father you did not have, she said, or running from the fear that you will fail the way he failed — and neither of

So if you are a father without a father, hear me: you are not disqualified, and you are not destined to repeat what was done to you, or what was never done — but the wound will define your fathering if you leave it untreated, because untreated wounds leak into every relationship, and the one they leak into most is the relationship with the small person who looks up and calls you Dad. Take it to God, and to people who can help you carry it — a counselor, a mentor, a friend who will listen without flinching. You do not need a father who modeled it in order to become one, because God is the Father, and He is faithful to give you, over time, what no earthly father gave. I am living evidence. I did not have it. He has been giving it to me for twenty-five years, slowly, and He has let me hand pieces of it to my sons, and the pieces are holding. The past did not finish you. Go to the Father. Let Him father you. Then go home, and father them.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Single Parents, Blended Families, and the God Who Holds

*Raising children in the faith as a single parent or
blended family — discipleship that holds when
the household does not match the picture.*

I have written the last several chapters with one household in mind — two parents, married, both present, both professing faith — because that is the picture most Christian parenting books assume, and I have assumed it too, since it is the household I live in and the one I know best. But if I stop there I fail a great many of the people reading this, many of whom are not in that picture at all; and the implication, rarely stated outright but always felt, is that a household which does not match the picture has children whose formation is compromised beyond repair.

That implication is a lie, and it needs to be named as one, plainly, so that the parent reading this in a house that

Single parents are doing the work of formation in millions of homes — single mothers more often than not, but single fathers too, some through divorce, some through death, some through circumstances they did not choose and would never have chosen. And the message they have received from the Christian world, sometimes spoken but more often delivered through silence, is that their household is deficient: that the absence of a second parent, a father above all, has opened a deficit that cannot be closed, that their children are statistically bound for worse outcomes, that the whole project is, at best, damaged goods.

I want to speak directly to that, because it is half true and entirely unhelpful.

The half that is true is this: two believing parents create a formation environment with structural advantages — more presence, more modeling, more reinforcement — and a child who watches a mother and a father both walk with God has two windows into the character of God. That is real, and I will not pretend otherwise.

The half that is a lie is the leap from advantage to impossibility. The absence of one parent does not make formation impossible, because the God who promises to be Father to the fatherless, who keeps particular watch over the widow and the orphan, has not left the single parent's household without resources; He promised to fill what is missing, and He meant it. I have watched Him do it. I have watched single mothers raise children whose faith went the distance, and single fathers carry a weight that would have flattened most people and still produce

A DIFFERENT HOUSEHOLD, NOT A BROKEN ONE

The single-parent home is not a damaged copy of the two-parent home; it is a different household, with different challenges and different graces, and the formation principles in this book apply to it without exception. The four channels of the household catechism still run — what you praise, what you worry about, what you repeat, what you rest in — and they run in a single-parent home exactly as they run anywhere else, because the child is still formed by proximity to the parent's actual life with God, and the parent's faith is still the primary curriculum.

What changes is the weight. The single parent carries more of it — the economic weight, the emotional weight, the logistical weight, the spiritual weight, all of it, and carries it without the partner who was supposed to share the load. That weight is real, and I will not spiritualize it into something lighter than it is. Some days it is crushing; some weeks; some years.

Which is precisely where the church is supposed to come in, as the extended family the single-parent household needs, the additional believing adults the child needs, the uncles and aunts and mentors the home cannot supply on its own. This is not a program. It is the body of

Let me be direct with the church for a moment. A congregation that praises the family and offers no concrete support to single parents is not a family church; it is a church for a certain kind of family, and the single parent feels the difference — she walks into the mother-daughter event and sits alone, he comes to the men's retreat and never hears his situation named, their children sit in the youth group and no one has asked whether they have a believing adult who is not their surviving parent. The church has to do better, not out of pity, but out of the theology it already confesses: if the body has members carrying more than they can carry alone, the body bears the burden with them. That is not optional. That is Galatians 6.

FAITH FORMATION IN A BLENDED FAMILY

The blended family has its own set of formation challenges, different from the single-parent home and almost never addressed in Christian parenting literature, because it is a household where children are being formed by adults who do not all share the same history. The stepparent enters mid-story, into a child who already has a past with a biological parent the stepparent was never part

Formation in a blended family is complicated, asking for more patience, more communication, and more grace than a household where everyone has been together from the start. The stepparent who claims full parental authority too quickly will usually be resisted; the biological parent who expects the child to transfer loyalty to the new spouse will usually be disappointed; and the household that pretends the blending is finished when it is not will breed confusion, because the child knows the truth even while the adults perform otherwise.

What I have seen work is a posture of presence without presumption — a stepparent who is present, consistent, and kind, who does not force the relationship but lets it grow at the child's pace rather than the adult's, while the biological parent supports the stepparent's authority in age-appropriate ways without requiring the child to feel about the stepparent the way they feel about their own. The household says openly that this family has a complex history, and that the complexity is not a failure but a reality God is present in.

The formation principles still apply. The household still has a catechism — what it praises, what it worries about, what it repeats, what it rests in — and the added complication is that the child may be absorbing two catechisms, one from each home, and the two may contradict. A child who spends weekdays in a home where Christ is the center and weekends in a home where Christ is irrelevant is receiving a divided inheritance, and that is

So hear this, blended-family parent: you are not at a disadvantage that disqualifies you from the work, but at a disadvantage that requires more of you — more prayer, more patience, more dependence on God, more willingness to hold the tension of a situation that does not resolve neatly. The formation that happens in a blended family is sometimes deeper than the formation in a family that was never broken, precisely because the blended family has no illusions about its own sufficiency; it knows it needs God, and that knowing is itself formative for the children who are watching.

THE COSTLY HOPE

The hope in this chapter is for every parent whose household does not match the picture on the cover of the parenting book, because God is not limited by your family structure — not by your marital status, the complexity of your custody arrangement, your ex-spouse's hostility to the faith, your age, your energy, your resources, or your mistakes. He is limited by nothing. He placed your children in your care, in this household, in this configuration, and He intends to use you to form them — not despite the difficulty. Through it.

*Let them see a faith that is not
decorative but necessary. The lifeline*

Let your children see you depend on God; let them see you carry what is too heavy and bring it to the One who carries you. That is real formation, and it is a faith the child will remember.

A PRACTICAL WORD FOR SINGLE CHRISTIAN PARENTS

You need practical words more than theological ones, because you already know God is with you. What you need is help.

First, accept help. Many single parents resist it, feeling they should manage alone and that to accept help is to admit defeat — but it is not defeat, it is wisdom, because God designed the body of Christ to share burdens. You are not failing when you let someone watch your children so you can rest, when you ask another family to bring your son on their camping trip, when you let the grandmother take the kids for a weekend so you can breathe; you are cooperating with the design.

Second, identify the believing adults your children need, because your child needs role models beyond you. If you are a single mother, your son needs godly men in his life — not a replacement father, a presence, a man who can take him fishing, teach him to change a tire, be the male image of God the household does not currently hold; and if you are a single father, your daughter needs godly women,

Third, do not let guilt drive your parenting. Many single parents compensate for the absent parent by going permissive, avoiding discipline, trying to be both good cop and bad cop and ending up neither, when what your children need is a parent who is clear, consistent, and loving rather than a parent performing compensation. The guilt is understandable; it is not useful. Bring it to God, let Him carry it, and then parent your children the way they need — with clarity, with warmth, and with the confidence of knowing that God put them in your care and equipped you for the task.

Fourth, tell your children the truth about your household, at a level they can receive, because children in single-parent homes carry unspoken questions — Why is my family different? Is something wrong with us? Did I cause this? — and you can answer those questions before the child has to ask. Tell them your family looks different and that God is in this family completely; tell them the absence of one parent is not the absence of God's provision; tell them you are doing this together, and that together includes God. Children can carry more truth than we think. What they cannot carry is silence, because silence breeds shame, while truth, spoken with love, breeds security.

There is a single mother in my church who has taught me more about formation than most two-parent families I know. She was divorced when her children were young, in circumstances that were painful and that she did not choose, and she found herself raising three children on a teacher's salary, in a small apartment, with no family nearby.

What she did was this: she built a household catechism with the materials she had. She could not afford the Christian school, the retreats, the summer camps — but what she could afford was time, and she spent it lavishly. Every evening she sat at the table and asked her children about their day, not casually but with attention; she prayed with them before bed, not for sixty seconds but for ten minutes, naming each child's specific concerns; she read the Bible to them, not from a curriculum but from wherever she happened to be reading herself, and she told them what it meant to her, in plain language, her own struggles included.

Her children are in their twenties now, and all three are walking with Jesus — and all three credit their mother's faith, not the church's programs, as the reason they believe. One of them told me the most formative thing about his childhood was hearing his mother pray; she prayed, he said, like she was talking to someone who was actually in the room. He believed God was real because his mother so clearly believed God was real, and her belief was neither inherited nor performed. It was forged — in the fire of raising three children alone while trusting a God she could not see to hold what she could not carry.



— GALATIANS 6:2

That woman's household was not the model. It was the principle. And the principle worked because the presence was real.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Grandparents and the Long Memory of Faith

*How grandparents pass on faith to grandchildren
— the long memory, the family story, and the
generational role Scripture gives them.*

Most parents read the seventy-eighth psalm as a parenting verse, and most grandparents have never once been told it is about them. Listen to how far it actually reaches:

*We will tell the next generation the praiseworthy
deeds of the Lord, his power, and the wonders he has
done. He commanded our ancestors to teach their
children, so the next generation would know them,
even the children yet to be born, and they in turn
would tell their children.*

— PSALM 78:4-6

Count the generations as the psalmist names them — ancestors, their children, the next generation, the children not yet born, and the children of those children — and you

The church has largely sidelined the grandparents from this conversation, and you can see it the moment you walk the parenting shelf at any bookstore, where you will find books for parents of toddlers and parents of teenagers and parents of prodigals, and almost nothing written for the grandparent. That silence is strange, because a grandparent is among the most formative presences a child will ever know — and the absence on that shelf is a loss the church has never bothered to measure.

WHAT CHRISTIAN GRANDPARENTS CARRY

Grandparents carry something parents simply do not have. Not schedule time. Deep time — the memory of decades, the accumulated evidence of God's faithfulness over a span of years the child's own parents have not yet lived long enough to witness.

A grandmother who has walked with God for fifty years carries fifty years of answered prayer, fifty years of sustained faith, fifty years of watching God work in rooms that everyone else had given up on, and that memory is not sentimental at all — it is evidentiary, the testimony of a life lived long enough to confirm what Scripture only

I think about my own congregation, where the most formative people in the lives of the young families are not the young families' peers but the older saints who have outlived their own fear. There is the woman in her seventies who has buried a husband, survived cancer, and raised four children, and who still weeps when she sings *How Great Thou Art*; there is the man in his eighties who fought in a war, lost a child, and rebuilt a marriage, and who will tell you with steady eyes that God has never once abandoned him. Their lives are the evidence — and in too many churches they sit in the back row, unasked, while the children's ministry combs the directory for twenty-five-year-old volunteers.

The grandparent's role is not supplementary; it is essential, because it fills the one gap a parent cannot fill — the gap between claimed faith and proven faith. A parent can tell a child that God is faithful, but a grandparent can tell a child that God has been faithful for sixty years, can point to the specific evidence and say I bet my whole life on it, I am still here, and He is still good. The child needs both voices. But the grandparent's testimony carries a weight the parent's claim has not yet earned, for the simple reason that the grandparent has lived long enough to prove it.

FOUR THINGS ONLY A GRANDPARENT CAN GIVE

Let me be specific about what a grandparent can do that

The first is story. Every family has a faith story, and in more families than anyone admits that story is dying in silence, because the only person who knows how the family came to faith — who prayed, who sacrificed, what the hard years actually cost, which prayers were answered and which miracles were small and which were not — is the grandparent who has never been asked to tell it. That story is the child's inheritance; it is the narrative in which the child's own faith finally makes sense. A child who knows that their grandmother came to Christ as a teenager in a small church in Alabama, that their grandfather came home from a war and built a life of faith out of the rubble, that their great-aunt prayed forty years for a wayward brother who came home in the end — that child has been set inside something old. The faith is not new. It has roots, it has tested itself against real years and held, and the child is simply the next chapter.

So tell it — at the dinner table, at Thanksgiving, in the car, while making cookies, while walking the dog. Tell it when the grandchild opens the door with a question, and tell it just as readily when they do not, because sometimes the story turns out to be the invitation they did not yet know they needed. The informality of the telling makes it more real, not less; the child who hears a conversion story over a bowl of ice cream has been handed something that will surface years later, at the exact moment they need it most.

The second is prayer. A parent's prayer is urgent, shaped by the daily crisis of the formation project and the

Monica prayed for Augustine for decades while he ran in every direction away from her — brilliant, rebellious, dissolute, lost — and she prayed, and she wept, and she followed him across the Mediterranean, and she prayed more, and in the end he came home. The greatest theologian in the history of the Western church was, before he was anything else, a mother's prayer project carried across years. Do not tell me prayer does not work. It works on a timeline longer than ours.

A parent can tell a child that God is faithful. A grandparent can tell a child that God has been faithful for sixty years, and here is the evidence.

The third is stability. There are seasons when the parents are simply overwhelmed — by illness, by money, by a marriage under strain, a job lost, a ministry burning

The fourth is love without the weight of the parenting role. The parent must enforce the rules and make the hard calls, but the grandparent gets to love without an agenda — to delight in the child rather than shape him, to be present without the pressure of the project. A child who has an adult who loves him that way, who is enjoyed rather than managed, celebrated rather than corrected, welcomed without having to perform first, carries a felt picture of the unconditional love of God that the parent, who must also discipline, cannot always provide. That delight is not indulgence. It is theology — it forms the child's capacity to receive the love of God at all.

A WORD TO CHRISTIAN GRANDPARENTS

Some of you feel sidelined — feel that the young parents do not want your input, that the culture has informed you your season is over, that you no longer understand the world your grandchildren are growing up in and therefore have nothing left to offer them.

None of it is true. You have a life behind you, and you have testimony, prayer, and presence still in your hands. You have a patience the young parents lack because they

So do not wait for an invitation; offer yourself. Call them. Write them letters — actual letters, on paper, the kind they can hold and keep and read again when they are thirty and you are gone. Tell them what you believe and why you believe it, tell them what God has done across the length of your life and what you pray for them now, tell them the specific things you see in them that remind you of His work. Do not assume they already know any of it. Tell them.

Many of you carry a harder tension — the one between wanting to guide and not wanting to overstep — because you see a grandchild raised in a way you would not have chosen, and you face the choice between speaking up and risking the relationship or staying silent and carrying the worry alone. There is no formula for it, but there is a principle: your primary gift is presence, not correction. If you must choose between being right and being present, choose presence, because a grandchild who has you — who knows you love him, who has heard your testimony and been prayed for by name — has a resource he can draw on later, even if the parenting you disagreed with produces the very crisis you feared. You will be there when it does. That matters more than winning an argument about bedtimes or screens.

The one exception is moral or physical danger; if you see genuine harm, you speak — clearly, and with love. But most of parenting lives in the gray, and in the gray your gift is patience, prayer, and presence. Not control.

I think about my own sons, and about the fact that they do not have grandparents who can tell them stories of multigenerational faith, because my mother came to faith later in life.

That long arc of generational faithfulness — the kind in which a grandparent can say, my grandmother prayed for me before I was born, and her mother prayed for her, and now I am praying for you — is not an arc I can give my sons, and it is something I grieve, quietly, precisely because I know the power of that kind of story and I know my sons do not have it. So if you can tell that story, understand that you are carrying something rare, and do not keep it to yourself. Tell it at Thanksgiving and tell it on ordinary Tuesdays when you are babysitting. The child will not remember every detail; he will remember that his grandparent had a story with God, and that he himself is part of it.

I want to speak to the grandparent who is raising grandchildren, and there are far more of you than anyone bothers to count. You stepped in when the parents could not or would not, and you are raising children at the age you thought you would finally rest; you are tired, you are afraid you are not enough, and you wonder whether the gap between your generation and theirs is simply too wide, whether they resent you for not being their parents. Hear this plainly: you are doing holy work. You are the stable ground under a child whose ground was taken away, the face of God's faithfulness to a child who has every reason to believe people leave. You do not need to be perfect. You need to be there — and you are. That is enough.

A WORD TO CHURCHES

Honor your elderly. They are not a demographic to manage; they are the long memory of the faith, and they carry the very stories the young families need most.

So create intergenerational space, and create it on purpose: let the old saints pray over the young families, let the grandmothers hold the babies while the young mothers breathe, let the grandfathers sit with the teenage boys and tell them what manhood has actually looked like across sixty years. Stop segregating the church by age group as though the generations had nothing to give one another, because they have everything to give one another — the relay in Psalm 78 requires the handoff, the handoff requires proximity, and proximity is the one thing our

And to the grandparent who has read this far: your role is not finished. It may, in fact, be entering its most important phase, because the prayers you pray now may be the prayers that bring your grandchildren home twenty years from now, the stories you tell now may be the ones they remember when everything else has been forgotten, and the love you give now may be the picture of God's love that surfaces at the moment of their greatest need. You are not retired from the work of formation. You are in the deep end of it. So stay there — pray, tell the stories, be present, and let the long memory of your faith become the foundation of theirs.

You are living in a culture that worships youth and discards age, and the church has too often followed it down that road, building its programs around the young while the elders sit in the pews with decades of tested faith and nobody asks them to testify. Resist that marginalization, because you have what the young do not — you have lived proof. So tell the stories, and not once but many times over, because the embedding requires repetition: tell the story of how you came to faith, the story of the hardest year of your life and how God carried you through it, the story of the prayer that took twenty years to answer, the marriage that almost broke and was rebuilt, the child who wandered and came home. Your grandchild may not seem the least bit interested. Tell it anyway — because ten years from now, or twenty, or thirty, in a moment of crisis you cannot foresee, the story will surface, and the memory of your faith will be the thing that holds when everything else gives way.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

When They Walk Away

*When an adult child walks away from the faith —
how to keep the door open, what to pray, and the
hope for parents of a prodigal child.*

There is a grief Christian parents carry in public because they have to, while it quietly breaks them in private — the grief of a child who has walked away from the faith. I have sat with parents in the middle of it, holding their hands across my office desk, and I have watched a mother's face collapse as she said out loud, for the first time in months, that she no longer knows whether her son believes anything at all; I have watched fathers go quiet for a long stretch and then admit, almost helplessly, that they do not know what they are supposed to do with this. I approach no chapter of this book with more care than this one, because the people reading it are sometimes bleeding, and what bleeding people need is not a platitude.

So let me name it plainly. Some of your children are going to walk away from the faith; some of them already

NAME WHAT YOU ARE ACTUALLY LOOKING AT

I need to draw a few distinctions here, because the distinctions change how you pray and how you respond — and because these children, who can feel identical to a frightened parent, are not the same at all.

There is the child in active rebellion, pushing against everything they were raised with and rejecting it loudly, often through choices you cannot endorse. This child is the easiest to identify and the hardest to answer, because the rebellion trips a parent's fear and a parent's anger in the same instant.

There is the child in honest questioning, who is not rebelling but thinking — who has met ideas that press hard against what they were taught and is genuinely working through them. They may skip church for a season, read authors you disagree with, say things that sound like unbelief but are in fact the sound of a mind in the middle

There is the child who has concluded, on the merits, that Christianity is not true. This one has arrived somewhere; they have thought it through and made their peace, and they are neither angry nor rebellious. This child needs a parent who can respect the dignity of their thinking while holding firmly to his own convictions, and who does not insult that thinking by treating the conclusion as a phase to be waited out.

There is the child wounded by the church — the one for whom something happened in a church context, a leader's failure, a community's hypocrisy, an injury inflicted by people who claimed to speak for God. Their departure is not from God; it is from the people who spoke for him. This child needs a parent who can separate the church's failures from God's character without ever defending the indefensible.

There is the child using unbelief as a permission slip — the one who has not examined the faith and found it wanting, but found it inconvenient and built a rationale for setting it aside. That is not an intellectual departure but a moral one, and because the root is different, the response must be different too.

And there is the child who is unsure and ashamed, the most common of all and the least visible — the one who has not walked away so much as drifted, who does not know what they believe and is afraid to say so, afraid above all of disappointing you. They perform faith while the faith

A PRODIGAL CHILD IS A CHAPTER, NOT A VERDICT

A child walking away is not the end of the story; it is a chapter — one that may run long, that may run the rest of your earthly life, but a chapter nonetheless and not the verdict. God is not finished simply because you have passed the age at which you could control the outcome.

The whole New Testament is crowded with people who came to Christ long after their mothers had stopped being able to make them, and Augustine is one of them — Monica prayed for him for decades, decades, and he came home. Some of your children may take exactly that long, which means you will have to do the hardest thing a parent of faith is ever asked to do: entrust them to the Father across years of not knowing, without curdling into bitterness on one side or collapsing into indulgence on the other.

And hear this carefully, because everything turns on it: your child's walking away is not a verdict on your parenting. It may expose things that need confession, or it may not. Many of the parents I have walked with through this grief were faithful — they did the work, they loved their children, they prayed over them, they made the hard calls — and the child still walked. Children are not products;

WHAT KEEPS THE DOOR OPEN, AND WHAT SLAMS IT SHUT

I have seen things that work and things that destroy families, so let me go in both directions and be specific about each, because vagueness is no kindness to a parent trying to decide what to do tonight.

What works is the open door — keep the relationship, keep the phone calls, keep inviting them to dinner, keep showing up for the grandchildren if there are grandchildren. Do not lecture them every time you see them, do not turn every conversation into an evangelistic appeal, do not treat them as a project; treat them, instead, as a person you love, who is loved by Christ, and whom Christ is pursuing in ways you will never see. The parent who keeps the door open is the parent the child is most likely to come back to when the season finally changes. It does not guarantee the return. It is what makes the return possible.

What destroys is the exact opposite, and it wears many faces: making your love conditional on their belief, withholding affection until they return, weaponizing Scripture in every conversation, grilling them about their spiritual life the moment they walk through the door, shaming them in public, triangulating other family

This will bother the stricter corners of the Christian parenting world, but I will say it anyway: tough love, in the way that phrase has been used over the last thirty years, has destroyed more relationships with prodigal children than it has ever restored. Look at the father in Luke 15, who did not chase his son down and drag him home, but who also did not cut him off in bitterness.

*While he was still a long way off, his father saw him
and felt compassion, and ran and embraced him
and kissed him.*

— LUKE 15:20

That is the pattern, and in its structure it is not complicated — let go, watch, and run to them when they turn — but in its execution it is brutal, because the watching is what breaks you. The years of watching and not knowing are the suffering, and God does not promise to remove that suffering; he promises to carry you through it.

THE SINS THAT FIND GRIEVING PARENTS

There is a sin pattern among grieving Christian parents that I have watched destroy people, and I want to name it, because it hides itself as faithfulness — the spiral of self-

If I had done this differently; if I had not sent her to that school; if I had held on tighter; if I had let go sooner; if I had prayed more, or prayed less, or not been so strict, so lenient — you can replay every parental decision you ever made, forever, and never once find the single one you can hold up as the cause. The grief wants a cause because a cause is manageable and mystery is not; stay with the mystery anyway. Confess where you were actually, specifically wrong, but do not confess a general indictment against yourself, because a general indictment is not repentance at all — it is self-punishment wearing repentance's clothes. Repent of what you did, and entrust what lies beyond that to God.

*The grief wants a cause because a
cause is manageable. Mystery is not.
Stay with the mystery anyway.*

There is a second pattern, and it happens more often than I can say: the weaponizing of the grief, in which the child's unbelief becomes a cudgel against your spouse. Two parents grieve differently — one wants to push harder, the other to back off — and the disagreement becomes blame, and the blame cracks the marriage. But the marriage is not supposed to be the casualty of the child's wandering; it is supposed to be the shared place where the two of you carry the weight together. Guard it. Pray together for the child, and refuse to turn against each

WHAT IS ACTUALLY IN YOUR HANDS: PRAYER AND PRESENCE

You need some practical counsel, so here it is, beginning with the plainest thing: do not go silent with your child, and keep the ordinary rhythms of relationship running even when everything in you wants to retreat into them being a project.

Text them about things that have nothing to do with faith — ask about work, ask about the dog, send a photo of something that made you think of them — and tell them you love them, often, without strings attached. Invite them over, and when they come, feed them well and let the conversation be about whatever they want it to be about. If they raise something spiritual, listen far more than you speak; if they ask what you think, answer honestly, briefly, and without escalating; and whatever you do, do not turn every encounter into a summit. Most of the time, just be their parent.

And pray — pray specifically and often, pray by name, pray the passages that match the exact place they are in. Pray with your spouse, pray with other parents living the same grief, and do not walk this alone, because the enemy wants you isolated for the simple reason that isolation is where parents fall apart. Find two or three believing parents and pray together for one another's children; do it weekly, and do it for years. I have seen children come home out of those prayer rooms.

Prepare yourself, too, for the possibility that you may not see the return in this life — it is a hard thing to say, and I say it only because it is true. Some children come home when you are old, some come home after you are gone, some come home in the last hour in a way that only God ever sees, and some, if we are going to be honest with one another, may not come home at all. This is the dark edge of the hope: you live in hope, and yet you do not know the outcome and you do not control it, so you entrust it to a Father who is both just and merciful — and whose mercy I would bet on, in the end, over my own reading of my child's trajectory any day. God is not a terrified parent. He is a steady one. Let him teach you his steadiness in the waiting.

TO THE PARENTS WHOSE PRODIGAL CAME HOME

I want to close with a word to the parents whose children did come back, because I have watched it happen after five years and after twenty, at thirty and at forty and at fifty — watched them come back quietly, without announcement, sometimes without telling their parents until months later, returning through a crisis, through a spouse, through the birth of their own child, through an illness that finally

The patterns of return are as varied as the patterns of departure, but a few threads run through nearly all of them, and the first is this: the child who comes back almost always says it was the parent's steady love they returned to. They do not say the parent's arguments convinced them. They say the love outlasted the rebellion, they say the door was always open, and they say the prayers were felt even when they pretended not to feel them.

They also often say that the faith they returned to is not the faith they left — that it is deeper, more honest, tested by the departure and refined by the return. They do not come back to a childhood faith; they come back to an adult faith forged in the furnace of their own doubt and their own failure, and that faith is frequently stronger than the faith of the child who never left, precisely because it was earned at greater cost.

If your child has come back, or is coming back, receive them — and do not make them perform gratitude for your faithfulness, do not say you told them so, do not require them to affirm every doctrine before you will welcome them. Welcome them the way the father in Luke 15 welcomed his son: with a ring and a robe and a feast, with extravagant joy, with the tears you have been holding for years, with the simple and devastating sentence that you were lost, and now you are found.

That is the gospel, and that is the hope, and that is what we have been building toward in every chapter of this book and every year of our children's lives — not a guarantee, but a hope, costly and earned and grief-tested and prayer-soaked, that God is the Father of our children, and that he

And if you are reading this in the middle of the grief, hear one last thing: you are loved by Christ, who sees your grief and is not angry with you for it but near to you in it. The children of God grieve with hope, which means you are not grieving wrong — you are grieving because you love. Keep loving. Keep praying. Keep the door open. And let the Father do what only a Father can do. He is working. Trust him.

CONCLUSION

The Long Obedience of Raising Believers

*The long, ordinary work of raising believers —
what faithful Christian parenting looks like on a
Tuesday when no one is watching.*

I will not restate the book. You read it, and a summary at this point would only insult your attention. What I owe you instead is a word about how to carry any of it into an ordinary Tuesday — because a Tuesday, when no one is watching and nothing feels significant, is where parenting actually happens. Every book ever written on this subject is finally worth only as much as it can be lived out on the kind of afternoon that leaves no record.

So let me close the way the book began: in my own house, with my own children, where the principles I believe were tested against the life I was actually living — and where I learned that the testing is the only proof that matters.

A YEAR IN LUKE WITH MY SON

On one of those nights he asked whether I thought Jesus actually rose from the dead. I told him I did, he asked why, and we spent an hour there. I did not hand him a canned answer. I walked him through what I actually believed — the historical evidence, the alternatives I had weighed, the reasons the resurrection has held for me under every alternative I have ever considered — and he listened, and then he was quiet for a long while. Finally he said, I think I believe it too, Dad. Not a declaration. A small report, at the end of a year of reading together.

That conversation did not happen because I had a program. It happened because we had built, over months, the slow practice of reading and talking; because the shape of my own life had given him reason to think the question was worth bringing to me; and because, when he brought it, I answered him honestly instead of defensively. That is formation. That is the thing I hope this book has been moving you toward, in whatever season you happen to be in with your own children.

FROM THE VALLEY, NOT THE SUMMIT

I began writing during a week when one of my sons was struggling — I will not name the son or the nature of it,

That is the honest context of this book. It was not written from a summit of parental achievement; it was written from the valley, from the place where the principles I believe in were being tested against the reality I was living in. And what I found, in the writing and in the living both, was that the principles held — not because they produced immediate results, because they did not, but because they were true. True things hold you even when you cannot feel them holding.

Formation is proximity to a formed life, and that held: even as my son pulled away, he stayed near enough to watch what I did with my own fear. He saw me pray about it rather than rage about it; he saw me stay in the room rather than walk out of it. I do not know what he made of the watching. I know that the watching was formation, whether it felt like it at the time or not.

And then the hardest thing held — that a child's faith is, in the end, between him and God. I had to let go: not of my parenting, not of my prayers, not of my presence, but of the outcome. I had to hand my son to God and say, he is Yours before he is mine, You love him more than I do, and I trust You with him even though I cannot see what You are doing. That surrender is the hardest act a Christian parent ever performs, and it is also the final act of formation —

*I am still in the story. I do not know
how it ends for my sons. They are still
being formed. They are still choosing.
And I am still in the room.*

THE SOIL: PLANTING FAITH AND TRUSTING THE HARVEST

I think about my mother. She raised me without a father, without faith, and without a model for any of the things I have written about in these pages. She did not form me in the Christian faith, because she did not have it to give — but she formed me in something the faith would later fill. She formed me in honesty: she told me the truth about our situation and refused to pretend we were fine when we were not. She worked two jobs, and cried in the kitchen when she thought I was asleep, and got up the next morning and did it again. What I absorbed from her was not theology. It was the refusal to quit.

When I came to faith in college, everything she had formed in me found its home. The honesty became confession; the endurance became perseverance; the refusal to quit became faithfulness. She did not give me the faith. But she gave me the soil — and the soil received the seed, and the seed grew.

This is the long obedience of raising believers. It is not dramatic, and it does not make for good social media; it is slow and hidden and mostly unnoticed, done in kitchens and cars and at bedsides, over decades, by parents who decided quietly that they would rather be faithful than impressive. It is the work of being near your children, for a long time, with a life actually turned toward God — in a house where grace lands the first word and truth is never softened — trusting that God will meet them in ways you could never orchestrate.



I will be a Father to the fatherless, and a husband to the widow. He sets the lonely in families.

— PSALM 68:5-6

So go. Into the kitchen. Into the car. Into the bedroom where the child is waiting for the blessing. Go with the confidence that the small thing you do tonight is the thing God will use — not because it is impressive, but because it is faithful. And faithfulness, in the economy of God, is the only currency that never loses its value. Go. Raise them.

